Haligric Research Integration Series

Buddhism

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Awakened One, the Four Noble Truths, and the Paths of Theravada, Zen, and the Pure Land

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A man sat down under a fig tree in northern India some twenty-four centuries ago and got up with a diagnosis.

Life hurts, he said. It hurts for a reason. The reason can be removed. Here is how.

He claimed no revelation and asked for no belief. He told people to try it and see, and when he was dying, he refused to name a successor.

What grew from that sentence now spans forest monks in Thailand, Zen gardens in Kyoto, a nurse chanting a Buddha's name in Taipei, and a stressed office worker counting breaths on a phone app in Houston.

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Introduction — The Religion Without a Creator

Buddhism is the fourth-largest religious tradition in the world. It began with a wandering teacher in the eastern Ganges plain in about the fifth century BCE, and it spread across much of Asia mostly through monks, merchants, and royal patrons rather than conquest, though its history is not free of violence. Pew Research Center counted about 324 million Buddhists in 2020, roughly 4.1 percent of humanity and about 98 percent of them living in the Asia-Pacific region. That figure was down from 343 million in 2010, a decline discussed later in this document.

The tradition's starting point differs from that of most religions in this library. It offers no creator God and no account of how the universe began, and it says that speculation on the subject does not help. It focuses on a practical problem: human beings suffer, and much of that suffering is produced by the way the mind grasps at a world that will not hold still. The Buddha compared himself to a doctor. He described the illness, the cause, the prognosis, and the treatment, and he asked people to test the treatment for themselves.

That simple account has to be held alongside the living religion, which is not simple at all. Buddhism has thousands of deities in some schools, heavens and hells, relics and pilgrimages, rituals for the dead, amulets, and vast monasteries. Most Buddhists throughout history have not meditated, and the religion they practice is one of devotion, merit, and care for ancestors. Modern Western presentations of Buddhism as a calm philosophy describe one thread of a far larger cloth.

This document fills a specific gap in the library. Tibetan Vajrayana and Bon, Shingon, and the Buddhist temple visitation guide already cover those subjects. The core religion, however, was never given a document of its own: the Buddha's life, the Four Noble Truths, Theravada, Zen, and the Pure Land. This is that document, and it points to the others rather than repeating them.

Origins — India in the Age of the Wanderers

The world that produced the Buddha was changing fast. New cities were rising along the Ganges, trade and coinage were spreading, and kingdoms were swallowing the older clan republics. Brahmin priests held the prestige of Vedic sacrifice, but a counterculture had appeared alongside them: the sramanas, wandering renunciants who abandoned home and society to pursue liberation through their own effort. Jain ascetics, whom this library covers separately, belonged to this world, as did the fatalist Ajivikas and various materialists and skeptics.

These wanderers shared some ideas that would become common Indian coin, including rebirth, karma as moral causation, and the hope of escape from the round of death and birth. They disagreed sharply over how that escape worked. That argument, carried on in parks and at the edges of towns, is where Buddhism begins, and it helps to read the Buddha as a participant in a lively debate, not a lone voice in silence.

Buddhism's own history reaches past him in one sense. The tradition teaches that he was not the first Buddha and will not be the last. Previous Buddhas discovered the same truth in earlier ages, it was forgotten, and a future Buddha, Maitreya, will rediscover it. The Buddha of this age founded nothing new, in this view. He rediscovered an ancient path overgrown by the forest.

The Life of Siddhartha Gautama — Legend and History

Nobody knows exactly when he lived. The old Sri Lankan chronology gives 624 to 544 BCE, or 566 to 486 BCE with a corrected date for Ashoka. Most early twentieth-century historians used 563 to 483 BCE. More recent scholarship tends to put his death around 400 BCE, give or take twenty years. He was born into the Shakya people at the edge of the eastern Gangetic world, whose capital was Kapilavastu. Later legend made his father,

Suddhodana, a great king. Historians think the Shakyas were more likely a small oligarchy and his father an elected chief.

The early texts say little about his youth. The full life story most Buddhists know comes from later biographies such as the Buddhacarita of the first century CE and the Nidanakatha of the fifth. In the traditional story, Queen Maya dreams of a white elephant and gives birth in the garden at Lumbini beneath a sal tree. Sages predict he will be a great king or a great renouncer. His father surrounds him with luxury. He marries Yasodhara and has a son, Rahula. Then, on trips outside the palace, he encounters an old man, a sick man, a corpse, and a wandering holy man. Scholars note that this story of the Four Sights was adapted from an older account about an earlier Buddha, Vipassi. Earlier texts simply say he was troubled by old age, sickness, and death. It carries a truth either way: comfort does not protect anyone.

At about twenty-nine he left home at night on his horse Kanthaka. He studied meditation under Alara Kalama and Uddaka Ramaputta, mastered what they taught, and left when it did not end suffering. He then joined five companions in extreme asceticism, and starved himself until, as the texts describe it, he could touch his spine through his belly. When this also failed, he accepted food, in legend a bowl of milk-rice from a woman named Sujata, and his companions walked away in disgust.

The lesson became the Middle Way: neither indulgence nor self-torture. He sat beneath a pipal tree at Bodh Gaya, and in the traditional telling faced Mara, the tempter, who sent armies and seductive daughters and finally questioned his right to sit there. He touched the earth to call it as his witness, the gesture seen on countless Buddha statues. In the course of the night he recalled his previous lives, saw beings dying and being reborn according to their karma, and understood the end of the craving that drives the whole process. He was about thirty-five. He was now the Buddha, the Awakened One.

He hesitated to teach, believing that no one would understand, until the god Brahma Sahampati persuaded him. In the Deer Park at Sarnath near Varanasi he found his five former companions and delivered his first sermon. For about forty-five years he walked the Ganges plain, teaching kings, merchants, courtesans, farmers, and thieves. His aunt and foster mother Mahapajapati led the first women into the order. His two chief women disciples were Uppalavanna and Khema, a vain queen of King Bimbisara who, tradition says, watched the Buddha conjure a beautiful woman and let her age and die before her eyes, saw her own fate in it, and awakened; he named Khema foremost in wisdom, and she later taught King Pasenadi that the Buddha's state after death cannot be defined. His two chief disciples came together. Sariputta met the monk Assaji in Rajagaha, asked about his teacher, and heard a one-line summary, that all things arise from causes, and recognized the path at once. He brought his childhood friend Moggallana, and 250 followers of their old teacher came with them. Sariputta became foremost in wisdom and Moggallana foremost in psychic power, and tradition says Sariputta died at his family home shortly before the Buddha. Among laypeople the physician Jivaka stood out. He treated the Buddha and the monks, gave a mango grove near Rajagaha as a monastery, and Thai tradition still honors him as the father of Thai massage and traditional medicine, invoking him in its healing ceremonies. The greatest lay patrons were the merchant Anathapindika, who bought the Jeta Grove for the order, and the laywoman Visakha, foremost in generosity, who funded the Pubbarama monastery near Savatthi, where the Buddha spent six rainy seasons, and who brought her skeptical father-in-law Migara to the teaching so that he called her his spiritual mother. His cousin Devadatta tried to take over the community and, the texts say, to kill him. At about eighty, ill after a meal, he lay down between two sal trees at Kushinagar. Asked about a successor, he refused to name one. He told his attendant Ananda that he had held nothing back in a closed fist, and that the teaching itself would be their guide. His final words in the Pali tradition were that all conditioned things pass away, and that they should strive on with diligence.

Archaeology continues to add detail around him. Ashoka's pillar marks Lumbini. In 2011 a team led by Robin Coningham and Kosh Prasad Acharya lifted an Ashokan brick pavement there and found the remains of a wooden structure beneath, dated to around 550 BCE. Root

traces suggest a tree shrine, which they read as possibly the earliest evidence of Buddhist practice anywhere, though that reading is still debated. An inscribed casket found at Piprahwa in 1898 by William Peppe carries a Brahmi inscription from about the third century BCE concerning the Buddha's relics. Gems found with those relics were set for a Sotheby's sale in Hong Kong in May 2025, until India's government threatened legal action. The Godrej group acquired them, and on July 30, 2025, they came home to India after 127 years, to be shown to the public. Excavation continues to add to the map. In January 2026 Indian reports described a Kushan-era stupa complex at Zehanpora in Kashmir's Baramulla district, of roughly the first to third century CE, as the region's largest known Buddhist site, first spotted in an old photograph held in a French museum archive. At Tilaurakot in Nepal, thought to be the old Shakya capital, a temple about 1,500 to 1,700 years old was reported in early 2026, built within a monastic complex that may overlie a royal palace, and showing that pilgrims kept coming for centuries. Scholars agree that a real person lived, taught, and founded an order during the reign of Bimbisara of Magadha. Early texts do not show an all-knowing superhuman. As Rupert Gethin has argued, the life story is best read for its pattern, the path every being must walk, rather than as a biography. Both readings are honest.

The Four Noble Truths

The first sermon, the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta, sets out the heart of the teaching in a medical structure. The First Noble Truth is dukkha, usually translated as suffering. The word is broader than pain. It covers the wrongness of a wheel out of true: birth, aging, illness, and death are dukkha, and so is being with what you dislike, being parted from what you love, and not getting what you want. Even pleasure carries it, because pleasure ends. Dukkha is a statement about the texture of unawakened experience. Teachers often divide it three ways. The dukkha of pain is the plain hurt of grief and illness, and the aversion to it. The dukkha of change hides inside pleasant things, because they end. The dukkha of conditioned existence is the subtler stress of a life built from shifting parts, felt in the anxious stories the mind spins about how things should be.

The Second Noble Truth is samudaya, the arising of suffering, and its cause is tanha, literally thirst. This covers craving for sense pleasure, craving to become something, and craving for things to stop being as they are. The Third Noble Truth is nirodha, cessation: suffering ends when that thirst ends. The Fourth is magga, the path that gets you there.

The Buddha assigned each truth its own task. Dukkha is to be understood. Craving is to be abandoned. Cessation is to be realized. The path is to be developed. This matters because the truths are often misread as a gloomy creed. They work more like instructions. Notice how much of your distress comes from wanting reality to be otherwise, and work on that.

The Arrow Sutta gives the point in a sentence-sized image. A person struck by an arrow suffers. A person who then grieves, rages, and laments has shot themselves with a second arrow. Pain comes with being a body. The second arrow is optional, and the path works on the second arrow.

The Noble Eightfold Path

The Fourth Truth breaks into eight factors, traditionally gathered under three headings. Wisdom includes right view, seeing the truths and how karma works, and right intention, the resolve toward renunciation, goodwill, and harmlessness. Ethical conduct includes right speech, avoiding lying, divisive talk, harsh words, and idle chatter; right action, not killing, stealing, or engaging in sexual misconduct; and right livelihood, avoiding trades that harm others, with the sale of weapons, living beings, meat, intoxicants, and poisons named in the texts.

Meditation includes right effort, the work of preventing and abandoning unwholesome states and of cultivating wholesome ones; right mindfulness, steady awareness of body,

feelings, mind, and phenomena; and right concentration, the deep unified absorptions called jhana.

The word translated as right, samma, means something closer to complete or fitting. The factors are not steps to be climbed one after another. They develop together, like strands of a rope, and most teachers describe them as a single training that begins with ethics, is stabilized by meditation, and matures in wisdom. A person cannot meditate well on a guilty conscience, which is why Buddhist practice nearly always starts with how you behave.

The Five Hindrances

The path's practical obstacles have names. Buddhist teachers list five hindrances that cloud the mind, and they come with one of the best images in the canon, from a discourse in the Samyutta Nikaya: the mind is a bowl of water in which you are trying to see your own reflection. Sensual desire is water mixed with dye. Ill will is water at the boil. Sloth and torpor are water covered with algae. Restlessness and worry are water whipped by the wind. Doubt is water that is muddy and left in the dark.

Each has a traditional remedy. Loving-kindness works on ill will. Bringing to mind a perception of light, or some physical energy, works on dullness. Calm works on restlessness, and careful investigation works on doubt. Anyone who has tried to sit quietly for ten minutes will recognize the whole list by the third minute, and the point of naming them is that you stop taking them personally. The water is disturbed. You can see how, and in time it settles.

Three Marks, Five Aggregates, and Not-Self

Buddhist philosophy rests on the Three Marks of Existence. All conditioned things are anicca, impermanent. All are dukkha, unsatisfying when clung to. And all things are anatta, without a self. This last mark is Buddhism's most distinctive and difficult claim, and it set the tradition apart from the Upanishadic teachers of its day, who sought an eternal atman at the core of the person.

The Buddha taught by taking the person apart. What you call yourself can be analyzed into five aggregates, or skandhas: form, the physical body; feeling, the pleasant, painful, or neutral tone of experience; perception, recognizing and labeling; mental formations, habits, intentions, and impulses; and consciousness, bare awareness. In the second discourse, the Anattalakkhana Sutta, he asks of each one: is it permanent, is it under your control, can you truly call it I or mine? The answer each time is no. No owner can be found behind the process. There is only the process.

This is an experiential claim as much as a metaphysical one. The texts present a set of practices for observing it, and a person who looks carefully can begin to see thoughts and moods arrive and leave on their own, without a commander giving orders. A 2025 review in Frontiers in Psychology, surveying research on different Buddhist meditations, reports that such changes in self-related thinking appear in measures of brain network activity, while noting that advanced no-self states remain hard to measure. The philosopher Evan Thompson's Why I Am Not a Buddhist, of 2020, pushes back from within the field, arguing against Buddhist exceptionalism, the idea that Buddhism alone is a rational science of mind, and calling the notion of a mindful brain a category mistake, since mindfulness is an embodied and social skill. Popular claims that Buddhism anticipated quantum physics, made famous by Fritjof Capra's The Tao of Physics in the 1970s, are another matter: critics say they mistake loose metaphors for equivalence, since quantum entanglement is a measured correlation while Buddhist interdependence is a philosophical claim about how to end suffering. Much of this research traces to the Mind and Life Institute, co-founded in 1987 by the neuroscientist Francisco Varela to bring scientists into dialogue with the Dalai Lama, dialogues that led directly to studies of meditation's effects on the brain and the immune system.

Buddhism then faces an obvious objection: if there is no self, who is reborn? The classic answer appears in the Questions of King Milinda, a dialogue between the monk Nagasena and the Indo-Greek king Menander. One flame lights another. Nothing solid travels across, and yet the second flame depends on the first. The chariot image works the same way. Take a chariot apart and you will find axle, wheels, and pole, with no thing called chariot. Chariot is a useful word for a set of parts. So is any personal name. So is I.

Dependent Origination and Karma

If nothing has a fixed essence, how does anything happen? The answer is pratityasamutpada, dependent origination: everything arises from conditions and ceases when those conditions cease. One early disciple summed up the entire teaching this way, and a Buddha is said to have the whole of his insight in it.

The best-known form is the Twelve Links, a chain describing how suffering rebuilds itself: ignorance conditions mental formations, which condition consciousness, then name-and-form, the six senses, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, birth, and at last aging and death. The Tibetan Wheel of Life, or bhavacakra, puts the entire teaching in one picture. At the hub, a pig, a snake, and a bird stand for ignorance, aversion, and desire, each biting the next. Around them, beings rise and fall by karma, and the six realms fill the next ring. The Twelve Links run around the rim, and the whole wheel is gripped by Yama, the figure of death and impermanence. Outside it, a Buddha points to the moon, showing that there is a way out. The chain can be read across lifetimes, and many teachers read it across a single moment. A sight arises, a pleasant feeling follows, craving catches, and a person has been reborn into a small new self of wanting. The critical link is the one between feeling and craving, and that is where mindfulness does its work.

Karma in Buddhism means intentional action, and that is its special emphasis. The Buddha said that it is intention that he called karma. Accidents are not karma. It works through the formation of habits and consequences, and it is not a cosmic accounting of fate, since many things happen from causes other than karma. The Buddhist texts explicitly reject the idea that everything in a person's life is caused by past karma, a point worth holding on to when someone suffers. The tradition lists three poisons as the roots of unwholesome action: greed, hatred, and delusion. Generosity, love, and wisdom are their opposites.

Nirvana — The Blowing Out

Nirvana, in Pali nibbana, literally means blowing out or extinguishing, as a flame goes out when its fuel is gone. What is blown out is greed, hatred, and delusion, and a person who has reached this state lives on, at peace, until the body's natural end. At death, the fully awakened one enters parinirvana and is not reborn. Texts call nirvana the unconditioned, the deathless, the island, the far shore.

Is it annihilation? The Buddha refused to say. When a monk asked whether an awakened being exists after death, he declined to answer, and his reply is one of the most famous in Buddhist literature, in the Culamalunkya Sutta. If a man is shot with a poisoned arrow, he said, he should not refuse treatment until he knows the name of the archer, the kind of bow, and the feathers on the shaft. Metaphysical questions like these were not useful for ending suffering, so he set them aside. It remains a striking religious moment, a founder choosing not to answer.

Theravada traditionally describes four stages of awakening. The stream-enterer has seen the truth and will be free within at most seven more lives. The once-returner will come back one more time. The non-returner will not return to the human realm. The arahant is fully freed. The Parable of the Raft completes the picture: the teaching is a raft for crossing the river, and a person who has crossed does not carry it on their back.

The Teaching Stories

The Buddha taught through images and stories as much as through doctrine, and many of them have become common property. The Kalama Sutta, addressed to villagers confused by rival preachers, advises them not to accept a claim because of tradition, or a teacher's reputation, or scripture alone, but to test it against whether it leads to harm or to well-being. Modern readers often cite it as a charter for free inquiry. Scholars add that it is a teaching for people who do not yet have faith, and not a rejection of the tradition's authority.

When the monk Sona strained so hard at walking meditation that his feet bled, the Buddha asked whether a lute plays well when its strings are too tight or too loose. Effort, like a string, must be tuned. That image is probably the most useful single piece of advice in Buddhist literature for anyone who practices anything. In the parable of the blind men and the elephant, each man touches one part of the animal and swears the elephant is a rope, a wall, or a pillar, and they come to blows, an image of how partial views harden into conflict.

The story of Angulimala tells of a feared killer who wore a garland of his victims' fingers. He chased the Buddha through a forest, unable to catch him, and shouted at him to stop. The Buddha replied that he had stopped long ago, and that it was Angulimala who should stop. The killer laid down his weapons and became a monk. People threw stones at him for the rest of his life, and he bore it. The story insists that no one is beyond change and that change does not erase consequences.

The simile of the saw, from the Kakacupama Sutta, sets the highest standard of patience in the tradition: even if bandits were sawing you limb from limb, whoever gave way to hatred would not be following the teaching. Few practitioners claim to meet it. It is there to show how far the idea of non-hatred is meant to go.

The Sangha and the First Councils

All Buddhists take refuge in the Three Jewels: the Buddha, the Dharma, his teaching, and the Sangha, the community of practitioners. In its narrow sense, the Sangha is the order of monks and nuns, bound by the Vinaya, the monastic code. Laypeople support them with food and robes, and in return receive teaching and the merit of giving. This exchange built the economic and social foundation of every Buddhist country. Theravada monks follow 227 rules, and the Dharmaguptaka code used in East Asia has 253.

Theravada tradition counts six great councils. The First met at Rajagaha shortly after the Buddha's death, where Ananda recited the discourses and Upali recited the monastic rules. The Second met at Vesali about a century later over disputes on monastic discipline. The Third, at Pataliputra under Ashoka, was headed by Moggaliputta-Tissa. The Fourth, in Sri Lanka in the first century BCE, committed the Pali Canon to writing after centuries of memorized transmission. The oldest Buddhist manuscripts actually found are older still. Birch-bark scrolls from Gandhara, in present-day Pakistan and Afghanistan, some dating to the first century BCE, are written in the Gandhari language and were often ritually buried in clay pots. Most match teachings preserved in Pali, but they also include early Mahayana sutras such as a Perfection of Wisdom text, which suggests that Buddhism had several canons from very early on. Other schools count differently, and a separate fourth council in Kashmir under King Kanishka is claimed by northern traditions. Historians question details of all of these. The Fifth, in Mandalay in 1871, had the canon carved on marble slabs, and the Sixth, in Yangon from 1954 to 1956, recited it again for the modern world.

Within a few centuries of the Buddha's death, a number of early schools had formed, conventionally counted as eighteen, of which only Theravada survives today. Scholars generally see the first splits as disputes about discipline, with doctrine following later. The first great division was between the Mahasanghika, the great community, and the Sthavira, the elders. The Mahasanghika accused the elders of adding rules, and Theravada sources accuse the Mahasanghika of changing them. Each side tells the story its own way, and the Sthavira line itself later divided into schools that include the ancestors of Theravada.

Ashoka and the Spread Across Asia

The event that turned Buddhism into a world religion was the reign of Ashoka, the Mauryan emperor, from about 268 to 232 BCE. His own inscription records that his conquest of Kalinga killed about a hundred thousand people in battle and deported a hundred and fifty thousand, and he expressed remorse in stone. He became a lay Buddhist, set up edicts across India promoting dhamma, a broad code of righteous conduct, and funded medical care for humans and animals, roadside trees, and wells. Historians caution that the edicts are partly political self-presentation, and that the drama of his conversion belongs to later legend. But his sponsorship was real, and the pillar he set at Lumbini is among the earliest hard evidence for the Buddha's life. Relics still draw devotion. Besides bone and teeth, many temples treasure sarira, small pearl- or crystal-like beads said to appear in the cremated ashes of the Buddha and great masters, which some believers say can multiply; in March 2026 Fo Guang Shan prepared to enshrine its late founder Hsing Yun's relic-bearing ashes at its American headquarters, and scholars note that fake relics are widely sold. Later Buddhists remembered him as the model of the cakravartin, the wheel-turning king who rules by righteousness rather than force, and his pillar at Sarnath, crowned around 250 BCE by four lions facing the four directions above wheels of the dharma, still sits at the heart of modern India's state symbols, its wheel on the national flag.

Sri Lankan tradition holds that his son Mahinda carried Buddhism to the island, and that his daughter Sanghamitta followed with a sapling of the Bodhi Tree to found an order of nuns. Some historians doubt parts of this, particularly regarding Sanghamitta. Sri Lanka still marks Mahinda's arrival every June on Poson Poya. On the full moon of June 29, 2026, police reported more than a million devotees in Anuradhapura, with more than 25,000 keeping the precepts in one royal park, and over 700 free food stalls, dansalas, feeding pilgrims on their way to Mihintale and the sacred Bodhi tree. Every full moon in Sri Lanka is a Poya day and a public holiday. Either way, Sri Lanka became the great conservatory of Theravada, based at the Mahavihara in Anuradhapura.

From northwest India, Buddhism moved up the Silk Road. Greek-influenced artists in Gandhara, along with sculptors at Mathura, produced some of the first statues of the Buddha around the start of the Common Era, ending an earlier period in which he was represented by symbols like a wheel, a footprint, or an empty seat. It reached China by the first century CE, where translators such as Chinese tradition tells of Emperor Ming of Han dreaming of a golden man, sending envoys west, and welcoming two Indian monks who arrived on white horses with scriptures, so that the White Horse Temple near Luoyang, traditionally dated to 68 CE, counts as China's first; most scholars see the story as a pious legend. The earliest known translator, the monk An Shigao, settled in the Han capital Luoyang in 148 CE, later legend making him a Parthian prince who gave up his throne, and his surviving works teach meditation and basic doctrine. Kumarajiva and the pilgrim Xuanzang brought the scriptures into Chinese, and the monk Faxian walked from Chang'an to India between 399 and 414 because the Chinese copies of the monastic rules were incomplete, a task that took centuries. It reached Korea in the fourth century, Japan in the sixth, when the Korean kingdom of Baekje sent images and scriptures to the Yamato court, by tradition in 538 or 552. The Korean-descended Soga clan championed the new faith against Shinto-loyal clans, and Prince Shotoku, regent from 594, built temples including Horyuji and in 604 issued the Seventeen Article Constitution, which joins Buddhist and Confucian ideals of harmony. It reached Tibet in the seventh and eighth centuries, and Southeast Asia by sea. In Sumatra, the maritime kingdom of Srivijaya, centered on Palembang from the seventh century, became a great Buddhist center; the Chinese pilgrim Yijing stopped there in 671 on his way to India and counted more than a thousand monks. In what is now Thailand, King Ramkhamhaeng of Sukhothai, who reigned about 1275 to 1298, made Theravada the state religion, and his successor Lu Thai wrote the Traibhumikatha, a Thai account of the three worlds of Buddhist cosmology, before Sukhothai was absorbed by Ayutthaya in 1438. Monuments mark the route: the Mogao Caves at Dunhuang, Borobudur on Java, the Champa monastery of Dong Duong in central Vietnam, founded by King Indravarman II in 875, Bagan in Myanmar, capital of King Anawrahta, who reigned from 1044 to 1077, was converted to Theravada by the Mon monk Shin Arahan, and turned his

people from the older Ari sect, the Bayon at Angkor Thom, whose stone faces show Cambodia's king Jayavarman VII, a devout Mahayana Buddhist of the late twelfth century, as a Buddha-king, before the Khmer people turned to Theravada by the mid-fourteenth century, and the giant Bamiyan Buddhas of Afghanistan, which the Taliban destroyed in March 2001.

In India itself, the tradition faded. Great monastic universities such as Nalanda drew scholars from across Asia for centuries. Hindu devotional movements absorbed much of the popular religion, and Hindu tradition eventually claimed the Buddha as an avatar of Vishnu. Royal patronage shifted, and around 1200 Turkic armies destroyed the great monasteries of the northeast. Nalanda, founded in 427, fell in 1193. In June 2024 India inaugurated a new Nalanda University campus at Rajgir, about 12 kilometers from the ruins, a revival begun by an act of Parliament in 2010 with backing from East Asian nations. By the thirteenth century Buddhism had largely vanished from the land of its birth, though it survived in the Himalayas and returned in the twentieth century in a surprising form.

China — Persecution, Repentance, and Survival

Buddhism's arrival in China was a long encounter between two great civilizations. Indian monasticism, with celibacy, shaved heads, and detachment from family, struck directly against Confucian duty to parents and the state. Buddhists answered by emphasizing filial devotion, which is one reason the Ullambana story became so beloved. Emperors swung between patronage and suspicion. Emperor Wu of Liang, who reigned in the early sixth century, was so devout that he gave himself to a monastery more than once and pressed for a vegetarian monastic rule, and it is to him that tradition attributes the Water-Land Rite, a great ritual for the salvation of all beings of water and land, still performed over several days at major temples.

The worst of the persecutions came in the Huichang era under Tang Emperor Wuzong. Between 842 and 845, with the treasury drained by war and the monasteries wealthy and tax-exempt, the state acted. The final edict of 845 reported that more than 4,600 monasteries and over 40,000 smaller shrines had been destroyed and about 260,500 monks and nuns returned to lay life. Wuzong died in 846 and his successor reversed course, but the scholastic schools never fully recovered. Zen and Pure Land, which needed few buildings or books, emerged as the survivors, a point that explains much of East Asian Buddhism's later shape.

Chinese popular devotion also transformed Avalokiteshvara. The bodhisattva, a male figure in India, gradually became the female Guanyin in China, a mother of mercy, a change that the scholar Chun-fang Yu has traced in detail. Lay people also adopted fangsheng, the release of captive animals, as a rite of compassion. It remains popular and now draws criticism, since mass releases can kill the animals and damage local ecosystems, and Singapore has restricted it during Vesak.

The twentieth century brought a new wave of destruction under Communist rule, especially in the Cultural Revolution, and a new vision from reformers such as Taixu, whose Humanistic Buddhism urged a religion concerned with this life and this world. That vision flourished in Taiwan through Fo Guang Shan, founded by Hsing Yun, and Tzu Chi, founded by the nun Cheng Yen in 1966, with its huge volunteer relief network. In Taiwan, unusually, nuns outnumber monks.

The Water-Land Rite — Step by Step

The Water-Land Rite, shuilu fahui, is the grandest ritual in Chinese Buddhism and one of the most elaborate in any religion. Tradition says Emperor Wu of Liang dreamed that a monk told him to hold a rite to relieve the suffering of all beings on land and in the seas. It was compiled by the Chan master Bao Zhi and later edited in the Song dynasty by Zongze and in the Ming by Zhuhong. Its purpose is to feed and ultimately liberate every being in the round of rebirth, from gods to hungry ghosts, and to dedicate the merit to all of them. Its

sister liturgy, the Emperor Liang Jeweled Repentance, follows ten volumes of rites invoking the names of 1,275 Buddhas, with participants prostrating and chanting together to acknowledge their faults and dedicate the merit to family and the dead. At Dharma Drum Mountain's Nung Chan Monastery in Taiwan, more than 7,000 people attended on a single opening day.

The temple is first purified, and the rite then runs through the day and night. The Inner Shrine holds twenty-four smaller altars, twelve for higher beings and twelve for lower ones. Step one: the boundary is set around the sacred space. Step two: the invitation is issued to the beings of all realms. Step three: higher beings are invited and given offerings. Step four: petitions are issued. Step five: lower beings are invited and given offerings. Step six: in the evening, precepts are given to the dead. Step seven: a final offering is made and the guests are sent off. At the Outer Shrine, meanwhile, assemblies recite sutras and call the name of Amitabha, in one requirement for at least seven full days. It is a vision of Buddhism in which even the dead can still be taught.

Korea and Japan — Reinvention Under Pressure

Korea's great early thinker was Wonhyo, who lived from 617 to 686. Setting out for Tang China with his friend Uisang, he sheltered one stormy night in what he took for a cave and drank sweet water from a gourd; at dawn he saw the cave was a tomb and the gourd a skull, realized that the mind makes the world it perceives, and turned back home. He later left the monastic order, married, and taught ordinary people with songs, dances, and chanting the Buddha's name. Korea's Seon tradition traces itself to Doui and the nine mountain schools of Unified Silla. Chinul, from 1158 to 1210, united meditation with scripture study, teaching sudden awakening followed by gradual cultivation. The Confucian Joseon dynasty then restricted Buddhism for five centuries and barred monks from the capital until 1895. Earlier, under the Goryeo kings, monks carved the entire canon onto 81,258 wooden printing blocks between 1237 and 1248, hoping the Buddha's power would turn back the Mongol invasions; the Tripitaka Koreana is still kept at Haeinsa, whose fifteenth-century storage halls UNESCO inscribed in 1995. Korean temples also honor older powers: behind and above the main hall stands a shrine to Sanshin, the mountain god, an old man with a tiger who was lord of the mountain before Buddhism came, often joined by the Seven Stars of the Big Dipper and the Lonely Saint. The tradition survived in mountain temples, and when Japan invaded in the 1590s, monks led by Hyujeong took up arms in defense of the country.

Under Japanese colonial rule, Korean monks were pushed to marry, following the Japanese pattern. After liberation a bitter purification movement from 1954 to 1962 sought to restore celibacy, and the modern Jogye Order was officially established in 1962. Married clergy formed the Taego Order in 1970. Jogye is South Korea's largest Buddhist order today. Korean Buddhists have also accused the state of bias. On August 27, 2008, some 55,000 people, thousands of them monks, rallied in Seoul after police searched the car of the Jogye Order's leader, charging that President Lee Myung-bak's government favored Christians. The order's own discipline has been tested in court: in 2017 it expelled Venerable Myeongjin, a former abbot of Seoul's Bongeunsa, after he criticized the order's finances on television, and on January 16, 2026, the Seoul High Court upheld a ruling that the expulsion was invalid. The order and he agreed to end the case and his monastic status was restored, but in August 2026 he died at 76 in an apparent freediving accident off Jeju. The order's Templestay program invites visitors into monastic life. Kyoim Yun's study in Asian Ethnology traces the program to the 2002 World Cup, when it was built for foreign visitors, and shows how it became a form of wellness tourism for Koreans worn down by a competitive economy, who pay to spend a day and night in a monastery for self-reflection.

Japan received Buddhism from Korea in the sixth century. The Nara schools, then Tendai and Shingon in the Heian period, were followed in the Kamakura period by the movements of Honen, Shinran, Nichiren, Eisai, and Dogen, which brought Buddhism to ordinary people. Tendai's home, Mount Hiei, keeps one of the hardest disciplines in any religion, the thousand-day kaihogyo, spread over seven years. Monks in white, the color of death, and

straw sandals walk about 26 miles a day, mostly before dawn, past some 260 prayer sites, reciting the mantra of Fudo Myo-o, and after 700 days they pray for nine days without food, water, sleep, or lying down. Only about thirteen monks completed it between the Second World War and 2010. Under the Tokugawa shogunate, every family had to register with a temple, the danka system, which secured Buddhism's income and earned it deep resentment. When the Meiji government separated Shinto and Buddhism in 1868, that resentment burst out in the movement called haibutsu kishaku, abolish the Buddha and destroy the sutras. An estimated 40,000 temples were destroyed nationwide, in some areas up to 80 percent, and historian Martin Collcutt judged Japanese Buddhism to be on the verge of eradication. The government then legalized clerical marriage in 1872, which is why most Japanese priests today have families and pass temples down to their children.

Most Japanese Buddhist practice happens at home, before the butsudan, the family altar. Step one: in the morning, open the doors and offer fresh rice, water or tea, and flowers. Step two: light a candle and incense. Step three: strike the bell, join the hands, and chant a short text or the name of the Buddha according to the family's school. Step four: address the memorial tablets of the ancestors, often simply telling them the family's news.

Key Texts of the Tradition

Buddhism has no single book, and its canons are vast. The Pali Tipitaka, the Three Baskets of Theravada, contains the Vinaya, the monastic rules; the Sutta Pitaka, the discourses; and the Abhidhamma, the systematic analysis of mind and matter. Within it, the Dhammapada, 423 verses of practical wisdom, is the most widely read Buddhist text in the world. The Jataka tales tell the Buddha's past lives. The oldest frame story places them in a long line of buddhas: ages ago a hermit named Sumedha laid his long hair across a muddy path so the buddha Dipankara could cross without soiling his feet, and Dipankara foretold that Sumedha would one day become Shakyamuni. Dipankara is still honored in Nepal as a protector of merchants and sailors. The Therigatha, the Verses of the Elder Nuns, preserves poems of women's awakening, and it may be the oldest collection of women's religious writing in the world. Its companion, the Theragatha, gathers 264 poems of elder monks, compiled over about three centuries, including the verses of Angulimala, the reformed killer, and Ananda's grief at the Buddha's passing; some borrow the shape of love songs and fill it with the joy of freedom.

Buddhaghosa, a scholar of the fourth to fifth centuries, wrote the Visuddhimagga, the Path of Purification, which became the standard map of the Theravada path. Mahayana added an enormous literature, composed from around the first century BCE on and presented as further teachings of the Buddha: the Perfection of Wisdom sutras, including the Heart Sutra and the Diamond Sutra; the Lotus Sutra; the Vimalakirti Sutra; the Avatamsaka or Flower Garland Sutra; the Pure Land sutras; and the Nirvana Sutra. Nagarjuna's Mulamadhyamakakarika is the keystone of Mahayana philosophy, and Shantideva's eighth-century Bodhicaryavatara is its most beloved guide to the compassionate life. The Chinese and Tibetan canons each run to well over a thousand works, and Zen added its Platform Sutra and collections of koans. Their authority has been argued over for nearly two thousand years. The Mahayana sutras open, like the older ones, with Ananda's words thus have I heard, yet they appeared from roughly four centuries after the Buddha and were still being composed in India until about 650 CE. Some Chinese monks as early as the fifth century rejected some or all of them, and modern scholars agree they were written long after the Buddha's lifetime. Mahayana tradition answers that they came through meditative revelation, and one well-known legend has Nagarjuna bringing the Perfection of Wisdom back from the realm of the nagas, who had guarded it until people were ready.

Theravada — The Way of the Elders

Theravada, the Way of the Elders, is the official or dominant Buddhism of Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia, and Laos, and about 36 percent of Buddhists in a 2010 estimate. It presents itself as the conservator of the earliest teaching, and it treats the Pali

Canon as authoritative. The ideal is the arahant, who has fully extinguished craving. Monasticism is central, and the sight of saffron robes on the morning alms round is the visible signature of the tradition across Southeast Asia.

The daily relationship between monastics and laypeople is the heart of it. Monks may own almost nothing and must receive their food. Laypeople kneel and place rice in the bowl, and they receive merit by doing so. Merit, punna, is a kind of spiritual savings, gained through generosity, ethics, and meditation, and it can be dedicated to others, including the dead. Most Theravada laypeople are aiming at a good rebirth, with nirvana understood as a far goal. In Thailand and Myanmar, a young man traditionally spends time as a monk or novice. In Myanmar this takes the form of the shinbyu ceremony, in which a boy is dressed as Prince Siddhartha and then has his head shaved and enters the monastery for a while, reenacting the great departure.

In the modern era, Theravada has seen a revival of meditation. Ledi Sayadaw in Burma taught vipassana to laypeople around 1900, which was a real break with custom. Mahasi Sayadaw developed the noting method after Burmese independence, and U Ba Khin's lay lineage reached the world through S. N. Goenka's ten-day silent retreats. A Bengali widow carried the Burmese method too. Dipa Ma, born Nani Bala Barua in 1911, turned to meditation in Rangoon after losing two children and then her husband in 1957, practiced under Mahasi Sayadaw's system and with Anagarika Munindra, and from 1967 taught from her home in Calcutta, devising practices that a mother with six children could do. Joseph Goldstein, Sharon Salzberg, and Jack Kornfield were among her students. The format is strict and free. Students keep five precepts, and returning students eight. They hold noble silence, with no talk, gestures, or notes between students, until the last full day. The bell rings at 4:00 a.m., meditation sessions fill the day, an evening discourse follows at 7:00 p.m., and lights go out at 9:30 p.m. Practice begins with watching the natural breath and moves on to observing body and mind. Courses run on donations given only by those who have finished one. In Thailand, Ajahn Mun, who lived from 1870 to 1949, restored the austere life of the forest monk, and the Thai Forest Tradition passed through Ajahn Chah to monasteries in Europe, America, and Australia. Ajahn Chah, who died in 1992, opened Wat Pah Nanachat for Western monks in 1975, and in 1977 he left his American student Ajahn Sumedho in London to found a Theravada monastery in England; his disciples now teach in more than 300 branch monasteries. One of them, the English-born Ajahn Jayasaro, ordained in 1980 and a Thai citizen since 2020, was raised by royal decree on July 12, 2026, to Somdet, the second-highest rank of the Thai sangha, the first foreign-born monk ever to hold it. Europe also has its own Buddhist homeland: Kalmykia, a republic of Russia settled by Mongol Kalmyks in the seventeenth century, is the continent's only Buddhist-majority region, and Russia's 1993 constitution names Buddhism among its traditional faiths. Much of what the West now calls mindfulness descends from these Burmese and Thai reforms.

Mahayana — The Great Vehicle

Mahayana, the Great Vehicle, emerged in India around the first century BCE or earlier and now accounts for the majority of the world's Buddhists, particularly in China, Taiwan, Vietnam, Korea, and Japan. Its central figure is the bodhisattva, a being who vows to become a Buddha for the benefit of all, postponing a private escape in favor of universal liberation. The motive is bodhicitta, the mind that seeks awakening for others. The path runs through six perfections: giving, ethical discipline, patience, diligence, meditation, and wisdom.

Nagarjuna, in about the second century CE, founded Madhyamaka, the Middle Way school, on the idea of sunyata, emptiness. Everything lacks inherent existence. That is not nihilism. It means nothing exists in isolation, and things exist through dependence. Thich Nhat Hanh coined a word for it, interbeing: look closely at a sheet of paper and you find the cloud in it, because without the cloud there is no rain, without rain no tree, and without the tree no paper. To keep this from dissolving ordinary life, he taught two truths. Conventional truth is the working world of people, promises, and consequences. Ultimate truth is emptiness. They are two ways of seeing one reality, and his verses say the ultimate cannot be taught

apart from the conventional. His famous statement is that nirvana and samsara are not two, a claim that would reshape everything after it. The brothers Asanga and Vasubandhu developed Yogacara, which examined how experience is constructed by the mind through levels of consciousness. Buddha-nature teaching, based on the idea that every being has the seed of awakening, took root especially in East Asia, and it changes the mood of the path: awakening is uncovered more than achieved.

Mahayana also rethought the Buddha. The Three Bodies doctrine holds that the historical Buddha was a nirmanakaya, an appearance; that glorious heavenly Buddhas are sambhogakaya, bodies of bliss; and that the dharmakaya, ultimate reality itself, is what a Buddha truly is. The Lotus Sutra teaches that the Buddha's lifespan is immeasurable, that his earlier teachings were skillful means, and that everyone will eventually become a Buddha. Its best-known parable makes the point. A father sees his house on fire while his children play inside, deaf to warnings, so he promises them carts drawn by goats, deer, and oxen, and when they run out he gives each of them a far finer cart drawn by a great white ox. The three small carts are the three paths, and the great cart is the one vehicle they were always part of. Another chapter has the eight-year-old daughter of the dragon king Sagara offer a jewel to the Buddha and attain awakening on the spot, a story often cited on women's capacity for enlightenment. The dragon kings themselves, Chinese renderings of the naga kings, became protectors of the Dharma, and esoteric monks in China and Japan, Kukai among them, performed rites invoking them for rain. In China, the Tiantai school, led by Zhiyi from 538 to 597, and the Huayan school, with its vision of all things interpenetrating like the jewels in Indra's net, built vast philosophical systems on this ground.

Vajrayana, the Diamond Vehicle, grew from Mahayana into a tantric path. Nepal's Kathmandu Valley keeps a living Sanskrit-based form of it among the Newar people, where married priests of the Vajracharya and Shakya castes serve families from courtyard monasteries called bahas, with festivals like Samyak displaying great Buddha images, though scholars say the tradition is losing ground to Theravada. The Tibetan form is covered in this library's Tibetan Vajrayana and Bon document, while Japan's esoteric lineage is covered in the Shingon document.

Zen — The Way of Sitting

Zen, Chan in Chinese, Seon in Korean, and Thien in Vietnamese, comes from the Sanskrit dhyana, meditation. It formed in Tang-dynasty China by joining Indian Mahayana philosophy to a Chinese sensibility shaped by Taoism. Its origin story names Bodhidharma, a semi-legendary Indian or Central Asian monk, who is said to have arrived in China around the fifth or sixth century, told an emperor that good deeds earned no merit, and sat facing a wall for nine years. Zen traces its line further back still, to the Flower Sermon: the Buddha silently held up a flower, only the disciple Mahakasyapa smiled, and the Buddha entrusted him with a teaching that does not rest on words or letters. The story first appears in a Chinese text of 1036, about fourteen centuries after the Buddha's lifetime. Tradition sums up the school's identity in four lines: a special transmission outside the scriptures, not founded on words, pointing directly at the human mind, seeing one's nature and becoming a Buddha.

The Platform Sutra tells the story of Huineng, a poor southern firewood seller who outdid a learned head monk with a poem and received the patriarch's robe in secret. Whatever the history, its message is that awakening is sudden, available, and not the property of the educated. Linji, in the ninth century, taught in shouts and shocks, and the record attributes to him the line: if you meet the Buddha, kill the Buddha. That is a warning about clinging to any image, including the holiest.

Japan received Zen through Eisai, who lived from 1141 to 1215 and brought Rinzai, and Dogen, who lived from 1200 to 1253 and brought Soto. Rinzai emphasizes the koan, a puzzle-case meant to exhaust the thinking mind: What is the sound of one hand? What was your face before your parents were born? Hakuin, in the eighteenth century, organized the koan curriculum, a training that can take about fifteen years. Soto emphasizes shikantaza,

just sitting, with Dogen's central claim that practice and awakening are one and the same, so that sitting is not a means to anything. Japan's Zen also produced its rebels, like Ikkyu Sojun, who lived from 1394 to 1481, scorned the stiff formality of the official monasteries, wrote poetry and painted, and in old age led the rebuilding of Kyoto's Daitokuji after the Onin War. Chinul in Korea and the Thien tradition in Vietnam shaped their own forms. In Vietnam the king Tran Nhan Tong handed his throne to his son in 1299, became a hermit on Yen Tu mountain, and founded the Truc Lam, or Bamboo Grove, school, which joined meditation to civic duty and taught that the Buddha is in one's own heart, so practice can happen anywhere, and Vietnam often blends meditation with Pure Land chanting.

Zen shaped Japanese arts including tea, gardens, calligraphy, and archery, and entered the West through D. T. Suzuki's English writings and later through teachers such as Shunryu Suzuki, whose talks became Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind in 1970 and whose San Francisco Zen Center opened Tassajara, the first Zen training monastery outside Asia, in 1967. On March 26, 2026, at the end of a three-month retreat on impermanence, fire destroyed Tassajara's wooden meditation hall; no one was hurt, and monks with hoses and buckets held it back until firefighters arrived from an hour away. The former Anglican priest Alan Watts, whose The Way of Zen appeared in 1957, translated Zen for a mass Western audience on radio and in lectures. Music listened as well: Leonard Cohen began visiting Mount Baldy Zen Center in the 1970s and was ordained a monk in the mid-1990s with the name Jikan, noble silence, Tina Turner practiced Nichiren chanting through Soka Gakkai International, and the Beastie Boys' Adam Yauch founded the Milarepa Fund and organized Tibetan Freedom Concerts. The lay Sanbo Kyodan school, founded in 1954 by Hakuun Yasutani and blending Soto and Rinzai, trained many early Western teachers, including Philip Kapleau and Robert Aitken. Silicon Valley absorbed it too: Apple's Steve Jobs studied with the Soto priest Kobun Chino Otogawa, who officiated at his wedding in 1991, and he sat long retreats at Tassajara. The Beat writers carried it into popular culture. In Jack Kerouac's novel The Dharma Bums, the character Japhy Ryder, drawn from the poet Gary Snyder, teaches the narrator to meditate and live without possessions, and words like zen, dharma, and karma entered everyday English. Kerouac dedicated that novel to Hanshan, Cold Mountain, a Tang-era Chinese hermit poet of uncertain existence whose roughly 300 surviving poems Snyder translated in 1958. Japan's beloved hermit-monk Ryokan, who lived from 1758 to 1831, never ran a temple, forgot his alms rounds playing with village children, and left poems that Nobel laureate Yasunari Kawabata said carried the essence of Japan. Buddhist impermanence also shaped Japan's vocabulary of beauty: mono no aware, the poignant feeling for passing things, wabi-sabi, the beauty of the rustic, worn, and imperfect tied to the tea ceremony, and yugen, the beauty of what stays half hidden in mist and dusk. The dry garden, karesansui, carries the same spirit: at Kyoto's Ryoanji, a Zen temple since 1450, fifteen rocks stand in raked white gravel that monks rake into ripples each day, and from any spot on the veranda at least one rock stays hidden; tradition says only an awakened person sees the fifteenth. Scholars have since shown that Suzuki's Zen was a modern reframing that removed much of its ritual and institutional setting. Actual Zen monasteries are intensely ritualized places, with everything from eating to bathing laid down in procedure.

The Pure Land — The Path of Other-Power

If Zen is the path of effort, the Pure Land is its opposite pole, and it is probably the most widely practiced form of Buddhism in East Asia. Its founding story concerns a monk named Dharmakara who, eons ago, deliberated for five eons and made forty-eight vows, promising to create a perfect land where anyone could reach awakening with ease. He fulfilled the vows and became Amitabha, the Buddha of Infinite Light, in Japanese Amida, and his land is Sukhavati, the Land of Bliss, in the west. Rebirth there is not a heavenly reward, but a place where the conditions for final awakening are perfect.

Three texts carry the tradition: the longer and shorter Sukhavativyuha Sutras and the Contemplation Sutra. In China, Lushan Huiyuan's society on Mount Lu in 402 became a symbolic beginning. Tanluan, from 476 to 542, argued that self-power was too difficult in

such a degenerate age and that one must rely on other-power, the power of Amitabha's vow. Daochuo taught that the world had entered the Latter Days of the Dharma. Shandao, from 613 to 681, made spoken recitation of the name the center of the practice.

The practice is called nianfo in Chinese and nembutsu in Japanese: reciting Namo Amituofo or Namu Amida Butsu, I take refuge in Amitabha Buddha. Japan's Honen, who lived from 1133 to 1212, went further, declaring that this single practice was enough for anyone, and founded Jodo-shu. His disciple Shinran, who lived from 1173 to 1263, took the step that startled everyone. He married and ate meat, called himself neither monk nor layman, and taught that even the recitation is not your effort, but Amida's gift working through you. If a good person can be saved, he is reported to have said, how much more an evil one. Jodo Shinshu, the school that came from him, became one of the largest denominations in Japan.

The Pure Land path is a form of Buddhism built for people who know they will not become great meditators: farmers, mothers, the sick, the dying. Its comfort is real. So is its theological challenge to the older tradition's insistence on self-reliance, and the resemblance to grace in Christianity has been noted by scholars and by Christian missionaries in Japan for centuries.

Nichiren — The Lotus and the Daimoku

Behind these movements lay a teaching about time. The Dharma was said to pass through three ages, the True Dharma, the Semblance Dharma, and the Final Dharma, mappo, and in Japan a rough consensus held that the last age began in 1052. Some teachers answered by urging stricter discipline, and others by searching for a practice simple enough for a degenerate age. Nichiren, who lived from 1222 to 1282, was a Japanese priest who concluded that the Lotus Sutra was the only valid teaching for this degenerate age. In 1253 he began proclaiming the chant Nam-myoho-renge-kyo, devotion to the Lotus Sutra, as the essential practice. In 1260 he submitted a treatise, the Rissho Ankoku Ron, to the shogunate's former regent, arguing that the nation's disasters came from false Buddhist teachings and that the country would find peace by turning to the Lotus Sutra. He was attacked, exiled, and nearly executed, and his combative certainty is unusual in Buddhist history.

Practice centers on chanting the daimoku before the Gohonzon, a calligraphic mandala written by Nichiren or his successors. Nichiren lineages became some of the most significant modern Buddhist movements. Soka Gakkai, founded by Tsunesaburo Makiguchi in 1930, grew into a mass lay organization with an international arm founded by Daisaku Ikeda in 1975. Its members are also the main base of Komeito, the political party that was allied with the Liberal Democratic Party for 26 years, most of them in government, until it walked out of the coalition in October 2025, citing unease over political-funds scandals and the new LDP leader's views. Rissho Kosei-kai, founded in 1938, has focused on interfaith peace work. The modern appeal of these groups lies in the way they promise personal change through chanting in everyday life, with no monastery required.

Symbols and Sacred Art

For centuries after the Buddha's death, artists did not show his body. Early carvings at sites such as Sanchi show an empty seat, a tree, a footprint, or a wheel, and scholars still debate why. The wheel, or dharmachakra, has eight spokes for the Eightfold Path, and turning it stands for teaching. The lotus grows from mud to bloom clean above the water, and represents purity arising from the mess of ordinary life. The stupa began as a burial mound for relics and became a model of the universe, with its parts later linked in Tibetan form to earth, water, fire, air, and space. Walking around it clockwise is one of the oldest Buddhist devotions. Blessings carry the same power into ordinary life. At a Thai housewarming, step one: the family invites an odd number of monks, five, seven, or nine, often at a time chosen by an astrologer. Step two: a white sacred thread, sai sin, is wound around a Buddha image and the monks' seats. Step three: lunch is offered, first to the Buddha image and then to the

monks, finishing before noon. Step four: the monks chant, sprinkle holy water through the house, and may draw a protective yantra above the front door. A new Buddha image is not yet an object of worship until it is consecrated. In the Burmese form, typical of Theravada countries, the morning rite has four parts. Step one: offerings of candles, flowers, incense, and flags. Step two: chanting of protective suttas such as the Mangala, Metta, and Ratana. Step three: recitation of Dhammapada verse 153, through the round of many births I roamed, held to be the Buddha's first words on awakening. Step four: recitation of the Twelve Links. In China the eyes are dotted with a brush dipped in cinnabar, and until then the image is said to have closed eyes.

Mahayana and Vajrayana art draws on the Eight Auspicious Symbols: the lotus, the endless knot, the golden fish, the victory banner, the wheel, the treasure vase, the parasol, and the conch. Hand gestures, or mudras, signify specific actions: the earth-touching hand of the awakening, the raised palm of fearlessness, the turning hands of teaching. This library's mudra guide covers them in detail. The five-colored Buddhist flag, designed in Sri Lanka in the 1880s with Henry Steel Olcott's help and adopted by the World Fellowship of Buddhists in 1952, displays the colors of the aura said to have surrounded the Buddha at his awakening.

Wider Cosmology — Thirty-One Planes

Buddhism's lack of a creator does not mean it lacks a cosmos. The classic Theravada map lists thirty-one planes of existence, grouped into three worlds. The Sensuous World holds the eleven lowest realms: hell beings, animals, hungry ghosts, and asuras, followed by humans and six heavens of devas. The Fine-Material World holds sixteen realms of radiant beings, reached through deep meditative absorption, including the Pure Abodes, where only non-returners go. The Immaterial World holds four realms of pure mind, among them infinite space and nothingness. Mahayana teaching simplifies this into six realms: gods, asuras, humans, animals, hungry ghosts, and hells, the Wheel of Life.

Every realm is temporary. There is no eternal heaven or hell, since beings rise and fall according to karma, and even a long-lived god eventually dies. The gods of Indian religion are present in Buddhist stories as beings, Indra as Sakka and Brahma as a powerful but mistaken deity, yet they need the Dharma as much as anyone. Birth as a human is regarded as the best position, since gods are too comfortable to practice, and lower beings are too miserable.

Space and time are enormous. A central world mountain, Meru, stands surrounded by continents, one of which, Jambudvipa, holds humans, and universes form and dissolve over kalpas, ages so long the texts compare one to the time it would take a silk cloth, brushed once a century, to wear away a mountain. Many Buddhists today treat these realms as literal, others as states of mind. The tradition has space for both.

In Mahayana the sky is filled with compassionate figures. Avalokiteshvara, who became Guanyin in China and Kannon in Japan, hears the cries of the world and appears in whatever form will help. Manjushri embodies wisdom and wields a sword that cuts ignorance. Samantabhadra embodies practice. Ksitigarbha, Dizang or Jizo, vowed to empty the hells, and in Japan he protects travelers and children. Bhaisajyaguru, the Medicine Buddha, heals. Maitreya, the future Buddha, waits in Tusita Heaven. Below it, on the summit of Mount Meru, lies the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, ruled by Sakka, the Buddhist Indra. Tradition says the Buddha taught the Abhidharma there to his mother and descended at Sankassa, a scene carved at Sanchi. For millions of people, the living practice of Buddhism is a relationship with one of these beings. Serpent kings, the nagas, attend the Buddha's sermons in the texts. The best loved is Mucalinda, who rose from the earth when a seven-day storm broke about four weeks after the awakening and sheltered the meditating Buddha under his spread hood, a scene repeated across Southeast Asian art. Lower down stand the protectors, and with them a long record of absorbing local gods. Yakshas guarded early stupas as converted defenders of the faith. Hariti and Mahakala joined the Mahayana world. In Japan, Mahakala softened into Daikokuten, a guardian of households,

storehouses, and food, shown with a mallet, a sack, and rice bales, and counted among the Seven Lucky Gods. The Indian river goddess Saraswati became Benzaiten, protector of eloquence, music, and learning, and sometimes of wealth, usually shown playing a biwa lute. Another of the Seven Lucky Gods, Hotei, is the Chinese Budai, a wandering tenth-century monk with a cloth sack whom Chan Buddhists took for an incarnation of the future buddha Maitreya; his big belly and grin made him the Laughing Buddha, often mistaken in the West for the Buddha himself. The dawn goddess Marici, often riding a boar, became in Japan Marishiten, protector of samurai, who invoked her at sunrise. In Japan, buddhas were identified with kami, Mahavairochana with the sun goddess Amaterasu, and in Myanmar the nats are headed by Thagya Min, identified with Indra. At the outer gates of East Asian temples stand the Nio, two muscular guardians understood as forms of the bodhisattva Vajrapani. One stands open-mouthed, sounding a, the first letter of the Sanskrit alphabet, and the other closed-mouthed, sounding hum, the last, so that together they span the beginning and end of all things. Chinese temple halls often line their walls with the Eighteen Arhats, the luohan. Tradition says the Buddha charged a group of awakened disciples to stay in the world until Maitreya comes. The best known is Pindola Bharadvaja, rebuked by the Buddha for showing off his psychic powers; in Japan, as Binzuru, he sits outside temple halls as a healer, and visitors rub the part of his statue that matches their own ailment until it is worn smooth. Xuanzang's 654 translation of the Record on the Duration of the Law fixed sixteen names in China, two more were added by the late Tang, and Japan kept sixteen. The Four Heavenly Kings guard the directions: Dhritarashtra in the east with his lute, Virudhaka in the south with his sword, Virupaksha in the west with a serpent, and Vaishravana in the north with his umbrella. On certain days of each lunar month they are said to inspect the state of virtue among humans. Their hall is a standard part of Chinese temples.

Taking Refuge and the Daily Offering — Step by Step

A person becomes a Buddhist by taking refuge. The form is close to universal. Step one: before a Buddha image or a monk or nun, the person bows three times, with hands joined. Step two: they recite three times, in Pali or their own language: I go to the Buddha for refuge, I go to the Dharma for refuge, I go to the Sangha for refuge, known in Pali as Buddham saranam gacchami, Dhammam saranam gacchami, Sangham saranam gacchami. Step three: they accept the Five Precepts as training rules: to refrain from killing, from taking what is not given, from sexual misconduct, from false speech, and from intoxicants that cloud the mind. These are stated as personal undertakings, not divine commandments.

In Western Zen, formal commitment is jukai, receiving the precepts. Step one: the student asks to receive them, often after long study. Step two: over the following months they hand-sew a rakusu, a small bib-like robe worn around the neck. Step three: they copy out a lineage chart naming the teachers back to the Buddha. Step four: just before the ceremony the teacher writes on the back of the rakusu and gives a dharma name. Step five: in the hall, after bows and an invocation, the student takes the three refuges, the three pure precepts, and the ten grave precepts.

A home offering, or puja, is simple. Step one: clean the space and bow. Step two: offer a flower, a light, and incense. Traditional Theravada verses explain each: the flower fades, reminding the worshipper of impermanence, the light stands for wisdom, and the scent for virtue spreading. Step three: recite refuge, precepts, and a few verses in praise of the Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha. Step four: sit quietly or practice loving-kindness. Step five: dedicate the merit to all beings. Many Buddhists do this at dawn. At a temple or stupa, a person also walks around clockwise, keeping the sacred object on the right. Tibetans call this kora. At the Boudhanath stupa in Kathmandu, pilgrims start before dawn, chanting om mani padme hum, counting mala beads, spinning prayer wheels, and some making full-body prostrations around the whole circuit, then dedicate the merit to parents, teachers, the sick, and the dead. The busiest month is Saga Dawa, the fourth Tibetan month, when good deeds are believed to gain extra power, peaking on its full moon, Saga Dawa Duchen, which marks the Buddha's birth, awakening, and passing.

On Uposatha, the observance days falling at the new moon, the full moon, and the eighth days between them, devout laypeople take the Eight Precepts. To the five they add no eating after noon, no entertainment or adornment, and no high or luxurious beds, and the third precept becomes complete celibacy for the day. They wear white, bring morning food for the monks, make offerings, hear sermons, and join meditation, and in Thailand and China many stay overnight, often eating once and sleeping on a mat. Those who cannot go may meditate longer or chant at home. Mahayana calendars set six or ten such days a month. In the monastery, on new and full moons, four or more monks confess any violations and then recite the Patimokkha, the monastic rules, which takes thirty minutes to over an hour. For one day each week or two, a householder lives something like a monk.

The Alms Round — Step by Step

The alms round, pindapata in Pali, is the oldest continuous daily ritual in Buddhism, and it remains one of the most beautiful. Step one: around dawn, monks leave the monastery, usually barefoot and walking in single file by seniority, carrying the bowl beneath the outer robe. Step two: they walk slowly and silently with eyes lowered, and they do not ask for anything. They simply make themselves available. Step three: laypeople wait along the road, often having removed their shoes and kneeling, with rice and other food they cooked that morning. Step four: the bowl is uncovered, the food is placed in it, and the giver does not touch the monk. Step five: in many places, the monk chants a short blessing, and the giver may pour water to dedicate merit to the dead. Step six: the monks return and eat before noon.

No thanks are exchanged, because in Buddhist understanding the giver is the one who benefits. The practice keeps monks dependent on the community, and it keeps them visible and accountable. In Japan, the equivalent is takuhatsu, in which Zen trainees in groups of ten to fifteen walk single file, chanting, and residents fill their bowls. Theravada monks also now walk alms rounds in Portland, Brisbane, and New Jersey. Walking itself has become a public witness. In Vietnam in 2024, Thich Minh Tue, a wandering renunciant with no official monastic status who follows the old dhutanga ascetic practices, drew huge crowds as he walked barefoot across the country, until authorities intervened and his walk ended in June 2024. He later set out on foot for India. From October 26, 2025, to February 14, 2026, Venerable Bhikkhu Pannakara of the Huong Dao Vipassana Bhavana Center in Fort Worth, Texas, and a group of fellow monks walked about 2,300 miles to Washington, D.C., to speak for peace and loving-kindness, with his rescue dog Aloka, whose name means light in Pali, and millions followed the walk online. Food is never guaranteed, which is the discipline of it.

The Zen Retreat — Step by Step

Sesshin, literally gathering the mind, is the intensive retreat of Zen, often lasting about a week. Step one: the day begins before dawn with a bell or wooden clapper, and the participants take their places in the meditation hall in silence. Step two: they sit in periods of thirty to fifty minutes, in lotus, half-lotus, Burmese, or kneeling posture, with the eyes lowered, often counting the breath and settling attention in the lower abdomen. Step three: between sittings, they stand for kinhin, slow walking meditation. Step four: meals are taken in oryoki style, with nested bowls unwrapped and rewrapped by exact procedure, so that eating becomes part of the sitting. Step five: a short period of work, samu, follows, in which sweeping or cooking is treated as practice. Step six: students meet the teacher privately in dokusan to show their understanding. Step seven: the day closes with chanting and a final sitting. Periods of fatigue and pain are expected, and the discipline lies in watching them come and go.

Paritta — The Protective Chant, Step by Step

Paritta, meaning protection, is the Theravada practice of chanting specific verses to ward off danger and bring well-being, and it shows how a tradition without a creator God still answers the human need for blessing. It is used at house blessings, temple openings, illnesses, and funerals. Common texts include the Mangala Sutta, the Ratana Sutta, and the Karaniya Metta Sutta, and one verse from the Angulimala story is chanted as a blessing for expectant mothers.

In a Sri Lankan pirit ceremony: step one, the chanting area is prepared with jasmine, mustard seed, and popped rice, and leaves and grass are hung and laid. Step two, skilled monks take their places. Step three, they chant aloud, sometimes through the entire night, with texts repeated a set number of times, commonly seven or twenty-one. Step four, laypeople listen. Understanding the Pali is not considered necessary, and translation is not preferred. In Thailand, paritta texts are also printed on small cloths or tattooed on the skin in the practice of sak yant.

Monastic Ordination — Step by Step

Theravada ordination has two stages: pabbajja, going forth as a novice, and upasampada, higher ordination. For the novice ceremony: step one, the applicant asks a senior monk for ordination and waits for permission. Step two, he obtains robes, and his head is shaved. Step three, he bows three times, hands over the robes, and recites a set passage. Step four, he asks for the robes back and is helped into them. Step five, he formally requests ordination. Step six, the senior monk gives the Three Refuges and the Ten Training Rules, which he repeats in Pali. These are the eight precepts expanded, with a prohibition on handling gold and silver. Step seven, he asks the senior monk to be his preceptor, and he receives a new Pali name.

Higher ordination is a legal act by the community, conducted within a consecrated boundary. Step one: a teacher confirms that the candidate has his three robes and alms bowl. Step two: the candidate stands apart from the assembly and is instructed in the questions he must answer truthfully. Step three: he approaches, bows three times, kneels, and requests ordination. Step four: the motion, or kammavaca, is announced three times. Step five: he answers thirteen questions, including whether he has certain diseases, whether he is a free human male, whether he is in government service, whether he has parental permission, and whether he has his robes and bowl. Step six: the assembly is asked three times whether anyone objects. Silence means agreement, and he is now a bhikkhu, a monk. Step seven: he is immediately told the time of day, by which his seniority is counted, and instructed on the monk's life.

The question about being a human being comes with a folk story: a serpent is said to have once taken human form to ordain. East Asian ordination adds the bodhisattva vows, and in Tibetan contexts a further initiation is involved, as the Tibetan document describes.

The Festival Year — Step by Step

Vesak is the great Buddhist festival. Theravada countries mark the birth, awakening, and death of the Buddha together on the full moon of the sixth lunar month, generally in May. Step one: at dawn, devotees gather at temples to raise the Buddhist flag and sing hymns to the Three Jewels. Step two: they offer flowers, candles, and incense. Step three: many wear white and spend the day keeping the Eight Precepts. Step four: a small Buddha statue is bathed with water or sweet tea, recalling the heavenly offerings at his birth. Step five: people give to those in need and listen to teaching. Step six: at night in Thailand, the Wian Tian procession circles the temple three times by candlelight, and in Sri Lanka streets fill with lanterns. In Indonesia, about 25,000 people gathered at Borobudur for Waisak on May 31, 2026, the Buddhist year 2570. Some arrived on foot: 58 monks from Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, and Thailand walked 666 kilometers in twenty days, from a temple in Bali to

Borobudur, in a thudong pilgrimage they called a walk for peace. Step one: worshippers carry a flame from the eternal fire at Mrapen and water from the Jumprit spring. Step two: a three-kilometer procession walks from the ninth-century Mendut temple to Borobudur. Step three: prayers at the moment of the full moon, which in 2026 fell at 3:44:44 in the afternoon. Step four: at night, lanterns are released over the monument, 2,570 of them that year. Myanmar's new year, Thingyan, in mid-April, is a water festival with a Buddhist core. Step one: on the first day many keep the eight precepts, eating once before noon. Step two: Buddha images are washed with scented water from the head down. Step three: families give alms at monasteries, and many boys go through the shinbyu novice ceremony. Step four: fish rescued from drying ponds are released with a prayer on New Year's Day. In Vietnam, during the first three days of Tet, the Lunar New Year, households crowd the pagodas with flowers, incense, and fruit to pray for well-being and luck in the year ahead. Thailand's Songkran, the April new year, is best known abroad for water fights, but at its heart are three Buddhist acts: pouring water over Buddha images at home and in temples, rod nam dam hua, when the young pour scented water over elders' hands to ask forgiveness and blessing, and building small sand stupas at the temple, decorated with flags and flowers. Thailand's king changes the robes of the Emerald Buddha at each turn of the seasons. Step one: he climbs to the image in its gilded pavilion and offers a garland. Step two: he removes the old season's gold attire. Step three: he washes the image with lustral water from a conch shell, moving clockwise, and dries it with white cloth. Step four: he dresses it in the new season's attire. Step five: the water squeezed from the cloth is sprinkled as a blessing, and the rite closes with a candle-circling. Chinese Buddhists honor Guanyin three times a year, on the nineteenth day of the second, sixth, and ninth lunar months, marking her birth, awakening, and renunciation, with temple visits, vegetarian meals, charity, and chanting of the Universal Gateway chapter of the Lotus Sutra. In Thailand's northeast and Laos, the Vessantara festival, Bun Phawet, recites in a single long day and night all thirteen books of the Buddha's next-to-last life, the prince who gave away everything. Step one: villagers invite the protective spirit of the monk Upagupta into the temple. Step two: a procession offers a thousand balls of sticky rice, one for each verse. Step three: monks and villagers take turns reciting for twelve to eighteen hours. Step four: merit is dedicated to the dead, and a long painted scroll of the story is carried around the temple. Korea marks the Buddha's birthday with Yeondeunghoe, a lantern festival traced to Silla times and inscribed by UNESCO as intangible heritage in 2020: it opens by bathing a statue of the infant Buddha, families and temples make lotus lanterns of mulberry paper over bamboo or wire frames, and a lantern parade fills Seoul's streets. In Sri Lanka, Vesak turns streets into galleries: families make paper lanterns in the week before, giant lit panels called pandals tell the Buddha's past lives in pictures and verse, roadside dansalas give free food to all comers, and many devotees spend the day in white keeping the eight precepts. The World Fellowship of Buddhists formalized Vesak in 1950, and on December 15, 1999, the United Nations recognized it by Resolution 54/115. Vietnam hosted the UN Day of Vesak in Ho Chi Minh City in 2025. Japan and some Mahayana countries mark the events separately, on April 8, December 8, and February 15. On April 8 Japanese temples hold Kanbutsue, also called Hanamatsuri, the flower festival: small shrines decked with peonies and irises hold a basin with a statue of the newborn Buddha, and visitors pour amacha, a naturally sweet hydrangea tea, over it while praying for children's health. Two more full-moon days frame the Theravada year. Magha Puja, Sangha Day, in February or March, remembers 1,250 awakened monks who gathered without being summoned to hear the Buddha give the Ovada Patimokkha, the core of his teaching in a few verses, and in Thailand it too is marked with candlelit processions around the temple. Asalha Puja, Dhamma Day, in July, remembers the first sermon at the Deer Park, and the rains retreat begins the next day.

Vassa, the three-month rainy-season retreat, keeps monks in one place from about July to October. In Thailand it was traditional for young men to ordain for this period. The candidate is called nak, naga, after a legend of a serpent who took human form to become a monk and was sent away when his nature was revealed, though the Buddha let future candidates carry his name in his honor. The evening before, his head is shaved or he is bathed for merit, and on the day relatives carry him in white or princely dress to the temple in a procession, the hae nak, with music and dancing. Laypeople once carried wax to the

monks on bullock carts so they would have light through the three months, and in Ubon Ratchathani that gift grew into the Candle Festival, a parade of giant hand-carved wax floats showing Buddhist stories, which marked its 125th year in July 2026. It closes with Pavarana, a ceremony whose name means inviting admonition, and it may be the most unusual moment in the monastic year. Step one: a competent monk announces that the day has come. Step two: the senior monk arranges his robe, raises his joined hands, and asks the assembly three times to correct him on anything seen, heard, or suspected, promising to make amends. Step three: every junior monk does the same in turn. In some places, lanterns are released into the sky that evening. Laos's own sacred palladium is the Phra Bang, a gold-alloy Buddha given in 1359 to Fa Ngum, the first king of Lan Xang, which gave its name to Luang Prabang and is carried out each Lao New Year to be bathed by the faithful. In Laos the same day is Boun Awk Phansa. Step one: at dawn families bring sticky rice and other food to the temple, offer some to the Buddha, and pray with the monks. Step two: through the evening, temples and homes glow with lanterns the monks and novices have made. Step three: in Luang Prabang, villages carry great naga serpents of bamboo and paper, lit from inside with candles, down the main street with music and dancing. Step four: near Wat Xiengthong the naga boats are lowered into the Mekong, followed by small candlelit banana-leaf boats that carry away bad luck. Downriver, opposite Nong Khai in Thailand, crowds gather on the same full moon to watch pink and red fireballs rise from the Mekong, which many believe are shot by nagas celebrating the end of Lent; skeptics with drones say they are flares fired from the Lao bank. The retreat is followed by Kathina, in the month after, when laypeople process to the monastery with cloth for new robes. In northern Thailand the same season brings Yi Peng, held over three days ending on the full moon of the second Lanna month, usually in November. It is first a merit-making festival. Step one: on the first day, people prepare. Step two: on the eve of the full moon they go to the temple for chanting, meditation, and sermons such as the Thet Mahachat, make large community krathong filled with food as alms for the poor, and at night release khom loi, sky lanterns, as light offered toward the heavenly stupa said to hold a relic of the Buddha's hair. Releasing one is believed to free a person from misfortune, and people make wishes and honor ancestors. Step three: on the full moon they float krathong on the river. Clay lamps and hanging lanterns are lit throughout to honor the five Buddhas of this aeon. In the mahakathina form, the cloth is spun, woven, sewn, and dyed in a single day and night. The monastic community then awards the robe to a monk chosen by its members.

Ullambana, the Ghost Festival, falls on the fifteenth of the seventh lunar month and comes from a tender story. The monk Maudgalyayana used his powers to find his dead mother and saw her reborn as a starving hungry ghost. When he offered her rice, it turned to burning coal. The Buddha told him that her karma was too heavy for one person, but that offerings to the whole Sangha at the end of the retreat could free her. Today, families bring food to the temple to help parents, living and dead, for seven generations. Cambodia's version is Pchum Ben, fifteen days at the end of the rains retreat when the gates of hell are believed to open and ancestors back to seven generations come seeking food. Monks chant Pali suttas through the night, and at many temples rice balls are thrown or scattered into an empty field for the spirits, while temples following the canon have laypeople feed the living monks so the merit passes to the dead. In Japan the Ullambana rite became Obon, when ancestors are welcomed home with lanterns and dances. Nara's Todaiji has held Shuni-e every March since 752, a fortnight of repentance before the eleven-faced Kannon. Each night torch-bearers run blazing pine torches up to eight meters long along the balcony of the Nigatsudo hall, showering the crowd with sparks, and on the final night, around 2 a.m., monks draw sacred water from the Wakasa well by torchlight, offer it to Kannon, and share it with the public, the rite called Omizutori. During Obon, Japanese temples also hold segaki, feeding the hungry ghosts, especially the dead with no family to remember them. Its source is the story of Ananda meeting a ghost king with a burning mouth, and the Buddha teaching him a dharani that turns food into an offering for all ghosts. Step one: set out rice and water on a special altar, the segaki-dana. Step two: make offerings to the Three Jewels. Step three: chant the dharani over the food. Step four: dedicate it to all wandering beings and feed the monastic community. On New Year's Eve, Japanese temples ring their great bells 108 times in Joya no Kane, a number commonly tied to the 108 worldly passions; many strike 107 times before midnight and the last in the new year, and some let visitors take a turn, palms

joined before the bell. Gratitude reaches even tools: at hari kuyo, a memorial for needles, people bring broken and worn-out sewing needles to a shrine or temple and push them into soft tofu or konjac so they can rest after their work, thanking them for silent service. Japan keeps a second ancestral season, Higan, the seven days centered on each equinox. The name means the other shore, the far bank of nirvana across the river of rebirth, and Pure Land followers once watched the equinox sun set due west toward Amida's land. Step one: families sweep the grave, pull weeds, and wash the headstone. Step two: they set out flowers and light incense. Step three: they offer rice, water, and sweet rice balls, botamochi in spring and ohagi in autumn, at the grave or home altar. Step four: they attend Higan services at the temple, which tie the week to the six perfections. In Vietnam it is Vu Lan, a festival of filial piety: families visit graves and temples, set out offering trays of incense, flowers, tea, fruit, and sticky rice, release fish and birds, honor wandering souls, and hear monks read the Vu Lan scripture, while some monks now urge giving books to children instead of burning paper offerings. Chinese Buddhism's great rite for the hungry dead is the Yujia Yankou, the Flaming Mouth. Its story says a ghost king with a burning face warned Ananda that he would be reborn a hungry ghost, and the Buddha taught a dharani that feeds them. Step one: incense at the altar and processions. Step two: the presiding monk ascends the seat wearing the Five Buddha crown, enters concentration, and visualizes himself as Guanyin, with mantras and mudras throughout. Step three: the hungry ghosts are invited and summoned, obstacles are removed, and food is given, first openly and then esoterically. Step four: merit is dedicated, placards are burned while the Heart Sutra is recited, and the food is distributed. It is held for funerals, at the Ghost Festival, and for the living's protection. Other observances include the display of the tooth relic at Kandy in Sri Lanka, whose Esala Perahera is among the largest Buddhist processions in Asia. In the eighteenth century King Kirti Sri Rajasinha joined the processions of four temples of the gods, Natha, Vishnu, Kataragama, and Pattini, to the relic's own. Step one: the festival opens with the planting of a sacred post. Step two: several nights of the quieter Kumbal Perahera. Step three: the Randoli Perahera, when whip-crackers, drummers, fire dancers, and Kandyan dancers lead the temple tusker carrying the relic casket, with the original relic kept inside the temple, and the goddesses' palanquins follow. Step four: the grand finale on the full moon. Step five: a water-cutting rite at dawn in the Mahaweli River. Inside the temple the relic also receives daily thevava, three services a day: at dawn hewisi drums sound and the silver and golden doors open for jasmine offerings, at midday a meal is offered with oil lamps, and in the evening fresh flowers and gilan pasa, juices of honey, ginger, ghee, and palm sap, are offered, with only one assigned monk allowed to handle the vessels. Animal-welfare campaigners criticize the chained, costumed elephants the procession depends on. Another major observance is Rohatsu, Zen's week of intense meditation leading to December 8. China marks the same awakening on Laba, the eighth day of the twelfth lunar month, when temples, by a custom traced to the Song dynasty, give away Laba congee, an eight-treasure porridge of grains, beans, nuts, and dried fruit, in memory of the meal the Buddha is said to have eaten.

Pilgrimage — Step by Step

Pilgrimage is older than almost any other Buddhist institution. In Kathmandu, Swayambhunath, the Monkey Temple, whose painted Buddha eyes look out in four directions, tells its own origin story: the valley was once a lake where a radiant lotus bloomed, until the bodhisattva Manjushri cut a gorge with his sword to drain it. The Buddha is said to have named four places where a devotee should go: Lumbini, where he was born; Bodh Gaya, where he awakened; Sarnath, where he first taught; and Kushinagar, where he died. On July 25, 2026, UNESCO inscribed Sarnath's whole archaeological landscape, including the Dhamek and Dharmarajika stupas and the remains of Ashoka's pillar, on the World Heritage List, after nearly three decades on its tentative list. Later tradition added four more in northeastern India. Japan's oldest pilgrimage, the Saigoku route, more than 1,300 years old, links 33 temples of Kannon across over 1,000 kilometers of the Kansai region, from Seiganto-ji by the Nachi waterfall to Kegon-ji in Gifu, with pilgrims collecting a calligraphy stamp at each, and it has inspired more than 200 other 33-Kannon routes. China has four sacred mountains, Emei, Wutai, Putuo, and Jiuhua, each devoted to a bodhisattva.

The Shikoku pilgrimage in Japan is the great walking example, a circuit of 88 temples associated with Kukai, the founder of Shingon, over about 1,200 kilometers, taking some 30 to 60 days on foot. The route itself is read as a spiritual journey in four stages, one for each of Shikoku's old provinces: awakening, austerity, enlightenment, and nirvana. Step one: the pilgrim dresses in white, with a sedge hat and a staff, clothes that are said to double as burial dress. Step two: at each temple, the pilgrim washes at the entrance. Step three: at the main hall, the pilgrim offers coins and incense and leaves a name slip. Step four: they chant the Heart Sutra and the mantra of the temple's main image. Step five: they repeat similar offerings at the hall of Kobo Daishi. Step six: they have a stamp book inscribed, and they walk on. Local people still offer food and gifts to pilgrims along the road.

Death and the Dead — Step by Step

End-of-life ethics follow from the first precept: the monastic code forbids intentionally killing a human or urging someone to die, so most Buddhist teachers oppose euthanasia even when it looks compassionate, while holding that nothing requires prolonging dying by every possible means, and favoring hospice care with pain relief and a calm, clear mind at the end. Buddhism's relationship with death is one of its defining strengths, and Japan's temples are so closely tied to funerals that people speak of funeral Buddhism. That model is now under strain. Japan has about 180,000 religious corporations, and some estimates say more than a third could disappear by 2040 as supporters age and donations fall. Temples are adapting: some run temple lodgings mostly filled by foreign tourists, some host day care for the elderly with caregiver-certified monks, and some open monk cafes. Some now bury pets: Tokyo's Kannoji, the cat temple, has its own pet crematorium and holds 46 percent of its funerals and memorials for animals, while Pure Land scholars debate whether an animal can reach the Pure Land directly through a family's transfer of merit. Japan, especially in Shingon, also assigns memorial services to the Thirteen Buddhas, each figure presiding over one rite: Fudo on the seventh day after death, Jizo on the thirty-fifth, Yakushi on the forty-ninth, Kannon on the hundredth, Amida at the second anniversary, and Kokuzo at the thirty-second, which in Japanese counting is the thirty-third-year rite. Others are being sold. Religious corporation status brings tax breaks, so brokers list temples for buyers who may want the status more than the faith, one broker putting its price alone at about 30 million yen, and authorities suspect some purchases are for tax avoidance or money laundering. The Agency for Cultural Affairs has begun dissolving inactive corporations so they cannot be bought. In Theravada practice, step one: a dying person is encouraged to reflect on good deeds, as a calm mind at death is believed to support a good rebirth, and monks may chant protective texts. Step two: after the death, monks are invited to the home, and family members take refuge and precepts. Step three: at the funeral, a white cloth is offered to the monks, called pamsukula, recalling the rag robes of the first monks. Step four: the monks recite verses on impermanence, and the family slowly pours water from one vessel to another, symbolizing the transfer of merit to the deceased. Step five: cremation usually follows. Step six: a further merit-making ceremony is often held on the seventh day and at later anniversaries.

About 90 percent of Japanese funerals are Buddhist, and they follow a set order. Step one: a wake the evening before cremation, with sutra chanting by a priest. Step two: the farewell ceremony, where each mourner approaches the altar before the casket and photograph, pinches incense, raises it to the brow, drops it into the burner, and presses the palms together, with the number of gestures set by the school. Step three: the casket goes to the crematorium with the family, and the remains are later interred. Step four: a shared meal, and observances that run to the forty-ninth day. In Japan, the family receives a posthumous Buddhist name, kaimyo, on a wooden tablet kept at the home altar, and memorial services continue for years. The custom of offering to Jizo for children who have died, including miscarried and stillborn children, known as mizuko kuyo, has comforted many parents, though critics have accused some temples of exploiting grief for money. In Chinese tradition, rites over forty-nine days reflect the belief that a being passes through an intermediate state before rebirth, a teaching described at length in the Tibetan document's discussion of the bardo.

Buddhist care for the dying has also entered modern medicine. Frank Ostaseski founded the Zen Hospice Project in San Francisco in 1987, and its volunteers cared for people with AIDS, cancer, and other illnesses under a slogan that sums up the whole approach: stay close, do nothing. The practice most useful to the living may be maranasati, mindfulness of death. Practitioners recall daily that death is certain and its time unknown. This is not intended to be morbid. Its effect, the tradition claims, is to restore a sense of what matters.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Few traditions in this library offer as complete a set of practices for the mind as Buddhism does. Anapanasati, mindfulness of breathing, is the root: step one, sit in a stable posture with a straight back. Step two, rest attention on the breath at the nostrils or belly. Step three, count breaths from one to ten if that helps. Step four, when the mind wanders, notice it and return without scolding. The noticing is the practice. A wandering mind is not a failed session.

Metta, loving-kindness, is one of four sublime states, along with compassion, sympathetic joy, and equanimity. Step one: sit and silently repeat phrases toward yourself, such as may I be safe, may I be happy, may I be healthy, may I live with ease. Step two: extend the same phrases to someone who has helped you. Step three: to a friend. Step four: to a neutral person. Step five: to someone difficult. Step six: to all beings everywhere. A 2015 meta-analysis of 24 studies with 1,759 participants found that such practice increases daily positive emotions with medium effect sizes. Buddhaghosa's manual gives the same order of persons used today. The tradition begins with oneself on purpose.

Vipassana, in Mahasi Sayadaw's method, uses gentle mental notes: rising, falling, thinking, hearing, as each event occurs, training the mind to see impermanence directly. Walking meditation pairs attention with steps. Thich Nhat Hanh taught people to breathe and smile while walking, and to use ordinary sounds such as a telephone as a bell of mindfulness. Zazen is seated with the eyes lowered and the attention resting on posture and breath, often with a count to ten. A Zen meal, oryoki, turns eating into full attention. Before eating, Zen practitioners recite the Five Contemplations: to reflect on the work that brought the food, to ask whether one's conduct deserves it, to see greed as the obstacle, to take the meal as medicine, and to receive it for the sake of awakening. Dogen wrote an entire manual for the monastery cook, treating the preparation of rice as spiritual practice.

Prostration is the body's practice. In Theravada, the five-point form brings the palms, elbows, knees, toes, and forehead to the floor, three times, to the Buddha, Dhamma, and Sangha. In Vajrayana the whole body stretches out, and 100,000 prostrations form part of the preliminary practices before tantra. Zen teacher Philip Kapleau, quoting the master Bassui, called it horizontalizing the mast of ego.

Naikan, meaning looking inward, is a Japanese reflection method built by the Shin Buddhist Yoshimoto Ishin in the 1940s. He took mishirabe, a harsh discipline of sitting in a dark cave without food, water, or sleep, removed the austerities, and first offered the method to incarcerated youth. Choose one person in your life and ask three questions. What did I receive from this person? What did I return? What troubles did I cause them? Intensive Naikan is a week-long retreat of solitary reflection with brief interviews, and about 30 centers in Japan use it, including in mental health counseling and prisoner rehabilitation.

Even sleep has a form. The texts describe the lion's posture, lying on the right side with one foot resting on the other, entered mindfully, so that on waking the body is still composed, and the Buddha is shown lying this way at his death.

The Five Daily Recollections, taught in the Upajjhatthana Sutta, are a remarkable piece of daily medicine: I am subject to aging. I am subject to illness. I am subject to death. All that is dear to me will change and be lost. I am the owner of my actions. Said each morning, they take the shock out of ordinary losses. The Sigalovada Sutta gives practical advice to householders on money, friendship, marriage, and the respect owed between employers and workers. Marriage itself is not a Buddhist sacrament. It is treated as a secular

institution, monks bless a wedding with chanting and merit-making but do not officiate, and in Sri Lanka the couple stand on the decorated Poruwa platform in a Sinhalese rite.

Theravada keeps an older body practice, the contemplation of the thirty-two parts, from head hair, body hair, nails, teeth, and skin down through organs and fluids to urine. Step one: memorize the list forward and backward in its groups of five or six. Step two: picture each part's color, shape, and place. Step three: work one group at a time, then join them until the whole list runs easily both ways. Step four: see the body, your own and others', as a collection of parts that is impersonal and not a self, which loosens infatuation and vanity.

Thich Nhat Hanh taught a way to meet anger without suppressing it. Step one: notice it with mindful breathing and greet it, hello, my little anger. Step two: hold it tenderly, as a mother holds a crying baby. Step three: if it stays, keep breathing and walk mindfully. Step four: let that gentle attention soothe it, even before it is gone. Step five: look deeply into its roots, which is where it transforms. If your own mindfulness is weak, ask a friend in practice to sit or walk with you.

Korean Buddhists often begin the day with 108 bows of repentance. Step one: stand with palms together. Step two: kneel. Step three: place the hands on the floor and bow until the forehead rests between them. Step four: turn the palms up and lift them toward the ears. Step five: lower the hands, rise to kneeling, then stand, and repeat. Teachers suggest beginners start with about ten a day and build up, and many chant a Buddha's name with each bow.

Thailand's Buddhadasa Bhikkhu, who founded the forest center Suan Mokkh at age 26, taught that to work is to practice Dharma: do the task mindfully, without clinging to its results, and liberation is possible in this life, not only after many rebirths. Zen calls the same thing samu, work practice, when cleaning and gardening are done as meditation.

A caution for modern seekers: the so-called Tibetan singing bowls sold for sound baths have no clear Tibetan pedigree. A scholarly catalog of Tibetan ritual music lists no such bowls, Tibetans interviewed by Tricycle said they never saw them growing up, and the earliest known written mention is a 1972 album called Tibetan Bells. Their soothing sound may still help someone relax, but it is not an ancient Buddhist rite.

A modern Western teaching distills these methods into RAIN, credited to the teacher Michele McDonald and spread by Tara Brach. Step one, recognize: silently name the strongest feeling, such as I am caught up in anger right now. Step two, allow: let it be there without fighting it. Step three, investigate: gently notice what you are believing and where you feel it in the body. Step four, nurture: answer with kindness, perhaps a hand on the heart and a few comforting words, then notice what has shifted.

Equanimity is trained against what the Buddha called the eight worldly winds, four pairs that blow through every life: gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain. The practice is to let the body grow still, notice when craving or aversion pulls you after one of them, and return to the present, standing like a mountain that the winds touch but cannot move.

Japan offers a quiet practice anyone can try, shakyo, copying the Heart Sutra by hand. Step one: clean the room, offer incense, wash the hands, and sit upright. Step two: join the palms, recite the four great vows and the Heart Sutra. Step three: trace the characters slowly, beginning with the title; a mistake gets a dot and a corrected character in the margin. Step four: add a wish if you like, your name, the date, and humbly traced, then dedicate the merit. The finished copy is treated like a Buddha image and may be offered at a temple. No faith or fine handwriting is required.

For caregivers, Buddhist teachers offer practical guidance. Focus on what relieves suffering now, as in the parable of the poisoned arrow, rather than on unanswerable questions. Tune your effort like a harp string, alert yet relaxed, neither straining nor slack. Let the shared facts of illness, aging, and death soften resentment into compassion. And protect your own rest, because without balance compassion turns into exhaustion.

A short sutta, the Bhaddekaratta, or one auspicious night, sums up the present-moment practice: do not chase the past or build hopes on the future, see clearly what is arising now without being swept away, and do today what must be done, for death may come tomorrow; whoever lives so, day and night, has had an auspicious day. The Buddha's first lesson to his young son Rahula is a daily practice in itself: use your actions like a mirror. Before acting, ask whether it would harm yourself, others, or both, and if so do not do it. While acting, check again and stop if it is causing harm. Afterward, reflect: if it caused harm, admit it to a trusted fellow practitioner and resolve to restrain yourself; if it caused none, take joy in that. A forgiveness practice taught in Western insight circles works the same way on resentment: notice that holding it hurts you most, breathe the person's image into the chest and stay with any resistance until it softens, let the hurt rest there without struggle, and when you are ready silently say, I forgive you, because I know that what you did came from your own pain.

The backbone of Buddhist meditation is the Satipatthana Sutta's four foundations of mindfulness, practiced in stages. First, the body: breath, posture, movement, and the body's impermanence, which anchor you in the present. Second, feeling: noting whether each moment is pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, before it hardens into an emotion. Third, the mind: watching thoughts and moods arise, linger, and pass. Fourth, mental objects: seeing how the mind assembles a world from separate moments, which opens into insight into impermanence.

Thich Nhat Hanh and the nutritionist Lilian Cheung, in their book Savor, teach mindful eating with a single apple or tangerine. Step one: wash and dry the fruit. Step two: sit still, with no walking, driving, or reading, and breathe a few times. Step three: look at its color, scent, and weight, and consider where it came from, since, Thich Nhat Hanh said, ten thousand things made it possible. Step four: smile at it and take a slow bite, noticing taste and texture. Step five: chew each bite twenty to thirty times, staying with the taste and the nourishment.

The Tibetan water bowl offering is a daily home practice against stinginess, since water costs nothing and can be given without attachment. Thubten Chodron teaches it this way. Step one: clean the room and altar, make three prostrations, and set the motivation to help all beings. Step two: take up seven bowls, kept upside down because an empty bowl never sits upright on a shrine, and wipe them left to right. Step three: fill the top bowl, pour nearly all of it into the next, and set each bowl upright in a straight line, about a grain of rice apart, saying om ah hung with each. Step four: refill every bowl to a grain of rice from the top, neither spilling nor stingy. Step five: dedicate the merit. The bowls are taken down at the end of the day.

Nyungne, the Tibetan fasting retreat of thousand-armed Avalokiteshvara, is traced to Gelongma Palmo, an Indian nun said to have been cured of leprosy by the practice. One nyungne takes two days. Step one: take the eight vows before each session, the five precepts plus fasting, avoiding high seats, and giving up ornament, song, and dance. Step two: on the first day, eat one meal at noon and nothing after. Step three: on the second day, keep total silence and take no food or drink at all. Each day holds three sessions of prayer, mantra, and many prostrations, often starting around 4 a.m. A full cycle runs eight nyungnes, and the closing session is often timed to Lha Bab Duchen, the day the Buddha descended from the heaven of the thirty-three.

Tonglen, the Tibetan practice of taking and sending, turns the breath toward pain instead of away from it. Pema Chodron teaches it in four steps. Step one: rest the mind for a moment in openness. Step two: breathe in heat, darkness, and heaviness, and breathe out coolness, brightness, and light, until the image matches the breath. Step three: take in a real painful situation you care about, and if you are stuck, take in your own pain along with that of everyone who feels the same. Step four: widen the circle to all in that situation, including people you see as enemies.

Korean temple food, now admired worldwide, adds one more rule: besides meat, cooks avoid the five pungent vegetables, garlic, green onion, chives, wild chives, and a type of

leek, for a clean, mild taste meant to take as little as possible from nature. On food, the tradition varies. Theravada monks eat what is offered before noon and are not required to be vegetarian, unless they know an animal was killed for them. Chinese Buddhism made vegetarianism the monastic norm, and Japan's temple cuisine, shojin ryori, grew from that. Devotion has its own health risks: because laypeople offer monks rich food and sugary drinks, one report put obesity among Thai monks as high as 48 percent, and health and religious officials responded with a Monk Health Charter. Vietnam offers a different food remedy. Anthropologist Le Hoang Ngoc Yen, writing in 2024, studied a Zen temple about an hour from Ho Chi Minh City, known as the Brown Rice Temple, where patients with chronic illness and cancer follow a prescribed macrobiotic diet of brown rice and sesame salt that the temple ties to karma, merit, and spiritual cultivation. The Vinaya also lists medicines for monks, including ghee, butter, oil, honey, and molasses, and it records one of the tradition's most moving statements, spoken by the Buddha after he found a monk lying neglected in his own filth. He washed him with his own hands and told the monks that whoever would tend to him should tend the sick.

Modern research has followed. Jon Kabat-Zinn created Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction in 1979 at the University of Massachusetts Medical School, an eight-week secular course built from these practices. The psychologist Marsha Linehan practiced Zen for almost thirty years, first at Shasta Abbey and then with the Catholic priest and Zen master Willigis Jaeger in Germany, and built its radical acceptance into dialectical behavior therapy, whose very name comes from balancing acceptance with change. A 2014 review in JAMA Internal Medicine of 47 trials found moderate evidence that meditation programs help with anxiety, depression, and pain. A 2018 systematic review of 36 randomized trials found secular mindfulness courses relatively safe, with adverse events about as common as in control groups, though it noted that few trials monitored for them carefully. Researchers and retreat teachers also report that intensive practice can sometimes be destabilizing, and the tradition has said so for a very long time. C. Pierce Salguero's 2026 sourcebook, Meditation Sickness, gathers these warnings from Pali, Sanskrit, Chinese, Tibetan, and Japanese texts. East Asia called the condition chanbing or zenbyo, and such troubles were often diagnosed as disorders of wind, loong in Tibetan and lom in Thai. The Pali Great Discourse to Saccaka has the Buddha describe headaches from overconcentration. A fifth-century work from Khotan, the Secret Essentials for Curing Meditation Sickness, describes meditators driven mad by loud sounds that startled them. One early story even has monks taking their own lives after practicing a meditation he had taught, with the Buddha then changing his instruction. Traditional remedies include grounding, moving the attention down to the lower abdomen or the feet, along with visualization, chanting, acupuncture, and herbs. Hakuin described his own Zen sickness and cured it by visualizing butter melting down from the crown of his head. At Brown University, Willoughby Britton and Jared Lindahl have documented meditation-related harm since 2017, and Salguero reports that studies put the share of practitioners with adverse effects anywhere from 5 to 65 percent. Meditation is not a replacement for mental health care. A qualified teacher matters, and anyone in crisis should seek professional help.

The Householder's Ethics

Buddhism is often pictured as a monk's religion, but the Pali Canon spends a good deal of attention on people with jobs and families. The Buddha told the banker Anathapindika that a householder can know four kinds of happiness: the bliss of owning wealth honestly earned, of using it well and generously, of owing no debts, and, worth far more than the other three, of blameless conduct in body, speech, and mind. The Sigalovada Sutta opens with a young man who bows to the six directions out of duty to his late father. The Buddha gently reinterprets the gesture. East stands for parents, south for teachers, west for spouse and children, north for friends, below for workers, and above for spiritual guides. Each relationship runs both ways. Children support parents and parents guide children. Husbands respect wives and share authority with them. Employers assign fair work, give fair food and wages, care for sick workers, and grant time off.

The same text gives blunt advice on money: avoid drink, gambling, late nights in the streets, bad company, and idleness, because each one drains wealth. It suggests dividing income into portions, for living expenses, for business, and for savings. The Buddha's teaching to householders treats wealth honestly earned as a legitimate source of happiness, provided it is shared. These passages inspired E. F. Schumacher's essay on Buddhist economics, included in Small Is Beautiful in 1973, which asked what an economy would look like if its goal were well-being with the least possible consumption. Thailand's King Bhumibol Adulyadej turned a similar idea into national policy as the sufficiency economy, first sketched in a 1974 speech and pressed after the 1997 Asian financial crisis, built on the middle path of reasonableness, moderation, and prudence, though critics say it can be used to justify inequality. Bhutan made a version of that question national policy. King Jigme Singye Wangchuck began shaping Gross National Happiness in the early 1970s, it became a national objective in 1982, and Article 9 of the 2008 Constitution directs the state to promote the conditions for it. Bhutan's leaders call it more Bhutanese than Buddhist, but its surveys measure meditation, prayer, and non-violence, and track compassion, generosity, and calm against anger and selfishness.

Women in Buddhism

The texts say the Buddha, after initial reluctance and Ananda's intercession, allowed his aunt Mahapajapati and a group of women to ordain, and declared that women could reach full awakening. That was a radical statement for its time. The same story says he required them to accept eight special rules, the garudhammas, that placed every nun below every monk, and predicted the order would decline because of them. Scholars dispute whether those passages go back to the Buddha, and modern nuns have challenged them. The Therigatha shows what early nuns actually said. A woman named Patacara lost her entire family and found peace. Kisa Gotami, mad with grief, carried her dead child from door to door, and the Buddha told her to bring a mustard seed from a house where no one had died. She found no such house, and she understood.

The Theravada nuns' order died out in Sri Lanka around the eleventh century and in Burma around the thirteenth, and conservative monks argued that it could not be restored, since nuns' ordination requires nuns. The Mahayana lineage survived in China, Taiwan, Korea, and Vietnam. A revival began in 1996, when eleven women were ordained at Sarnath, followed by further ordinations in Bodh Gaya and Sri Lanka. The revival has cost some monks dearly: in October 2009 the English-born abbot Ajahn Brahm helped ordain four nuns in Western Australia, the first bhikkhuni ordination in the Thai Forest tradition, and on November 1 the senior monks of Ajahn Chah's lineage voted to expel him. Sri Lanka's state has been slow to follow: only on June 16, 2025, did its Supreme Court rule, on a petition filed in 2013 by Venerable Welimada Dhammadinna, that nuns may be named bhikkhuni on their national identity cards, finding the refusal a breach of equality and religious freedom, though some senior monks still deny that the nuns' order exists. In Thailand, a scholar named Chatsumarn Kabilsingh became Dhammananda Bhikkhuni in 2003, and in 2010 Ayya Tathaaloka helped lead a dual ordination in California. Thailand's main orders still do not officially recognize them, and a 1928 edict that barred monks from ordaining women remains a point of conflict. The international association Sakyadhita, founded at Bodh Gaya in 1987, has carried this cause forward. Its best-known modern voice may be Tenzin Palmo, born Diane Perry in England in 1943, who ordained in 1964, took full ordination in Hong Kong in 1973, and spent twelve years in a Himalayan cave from 1976 to 1988. She founded Dongyu Gatsal Ling Nunnery in India in 2000, received the title Jetsunma in 2008, and has vowed to reach enlightenment in a female form however many lifetimes it takes.

Legacy and Influence — Modern Buddhism

European colonialism and Christian missions forced Asian Buddhism to redefine itself. In Sri Lanka, the American Theosophist Henry Steel Olcott, whom this library's Theosophy document discusses, and the reformer Anagarika Dharmapala helped build a modernized Buddhism that emphasized reason and lay activity. Dharmapala founded the Maha Bodhi

Society in 1891 to win back Bodh Gaya, and at Chicago's 1893 World's Parliament of Religions he and the Japanese Zen teacher Soyen Shaku presented Buddhism to the West as a rational and scientific religion. Film carried the ideas further: Interbeing, the first official documentary of Thich Nhat Hanh's life, narrated by Benedict Cumberbatch from his journals and poems, went into production in 2025, and Star Wars' Jedi renounce attachment because it leads to the dark side, and Yoda's chain of fear, anger, hate, and suffering echoes the Buddhist account of craving and the three poisons. Fiction helped too: Hermann Hesse's novel Siddhartha, published in German in 1922 and in American English in 1951, follows a seeker in the Buddha's India, not the Buddha himself, and became something of a bible for the 1960s counterculture. European philosophers had already been listening. Schopenhauer called Buddhism the best of all possible religions, Nietzsche called it the only genuinely positive religion while rejecting its goal, and readers have long compared David Hume's self as a bundle of perceptions with the Buddhist five aggregates. The philosopher Derek Parfit, arguing in Reasons and Persons that a person is no more than a connected stream of mental and physical events, wrote that the Buddha would have agreed, and said the view made him care less about his own future and more about others. Britain received its first Buddhist mission in 1908, when the English chemist Allan Bennett, ordained in Burma as Ananda Metteyya, arrived in London and founded the Buddhist Society of Great Britain and Ireland. Christianity listened too. The Trappist monk Thomas Merton traveled to Asia in 1968, met the Dalai Lama three times at Dharamsala, and described a moment of sudden clarity before the great Buddha statues at Polonnaruwa in Sri Lanka, days before he died at a monastic conference near Bangkok. His openness helped start decades of Buddhist-Christian dialogue, and in 1996 the Dalai Lama knelt at his grave in Kentucky. Critics such as Donald Lopez have described the resulting scientific Buddha as a modern creation, and teachers such as Bhikkhu Bodhi have rejected attempts to set aside rebirth.

In India, the great return came from an unexpected direction. Dr. B. R. Ambedkar, the Dalit leader who chaired the drafting of India's constitution, concluded that caste could not be escaped within Hinduism. In October 1956 at Nagpur he converted to Buddhism, along with nearly 400,000 followers. At the ceremony on October 14 he gave twenty-two vows. Some bind converts to the precepts, the perfections, and the Eightfold Path, and others break with the old faith directly, refusing to treat Hindu gods as supreme or the Buddha as an incarnation of Vishnu. Several million more converted by the end of the decade. The movement, called Navayana, has grown since, treating Buddhism as a social liberation movement. It is among the most significant religious shifts in modern South Asia and a reminder of why the Buddha's rejection of caste by birth still matters. Buddhist institutions have not always lived up to it. In Sri Lanka a faction of the Siam Nikaya began in 1764 to restrict higher ordination to the Radala and Govigama castes, and monks of other castes went abroad for ordination, founding the Amarapura Nikaya after ordinations in Burma in 1800. In Japan, researchers have documented temple family registers recording outcaste burakumin lineages being used to judge marriage prospects.

Vietnam also gave the century its most shocking image of Buddhist protest. On June 11, 1963, the monk Thich Quang Duc burned himself to death at a Saigon intersection to protest the Diem government's favoring of Catholics. Malcolm Browne's photographs went around the world, and his heart, which reportedly did not burn, is kept at Xa Loi Pagoda.

Thich Nhat Hanh, who lived from 1926 to 2022, coined the term Engaged Buddhism in the context of the Vietnam War, founding the School of Youth for Social Service in 1964 and later the Plum Village community in France. His Fourteen Precepts took Buddhist ethics into public life. The same impulse turned green: the Karmapa's Khoryug network has greened Himalayan monasteries since 2009, and the Dalai Lama convened a climate dialogue in Dharamsala in 2011. The American teacher Joanna Macy, who died in 2025 at 96, joined Buddhist practice to systems theory and deep ecology in the Work That Reconnects, a training that moves from gratitude, to honoring one's pain for the world, to seeing with new eyes, to going forth to act. Ecology has also turned a critical eye on one old rite. Fangsheng, releasing life, goes back in China at least to the sixth century, when worshippers freed fish and tortoises into temple ponds for merit, often with monks chanting

over the animals. Today a commercial trade captures millions of animals for release, many die in transit, and released species such as bullfrogs and red-eared sliders become invasive. Some Buddhist teachers, such as the New York monk Benkong, now urge temples to work with licensed wildlife rehabilitators instead, so the merit comes without the harm. In Sri Lanka, the schoolteacher A. T. Ariyaratne founded Sarvodaya in 1958, a village self-help movement drawing on Buddhist and Gandhian ideals that grew to reach thousands of villages. The American monk and translator Bhikkhu Bodhi founded Buddhist Global Relief in 2008 to fight chronic hunger, funding nutrition programs in Africa and food scholarships for girls in Cambodia. Sulak Sivaraksa in Thailand, the Buddhist Peace Fellowship founded in 1978, and Taiwan's so-called Four Great Mountains, Hsing Yun's Fo Guang Shan of 1967, Cheng Yen's Tzu Chi relief foundation of 1966, begun in Hualien after she saw blood on a hospital floor where a woman had been turned away, funded at first by thirty housewives dropping fifty Taiwanese cents a day into bamboo banks, since she wanted the daily act of giving rather than a monthly sum, Sheng Yen's Dharma Drum Mountain, and Wei Chueh's meditation-centered Chung Tai Shan of 1987, have extended this work. One of the most striking rituals to come from it is the ordination of trees. Since the late 1980s, activist monks in Thailand such as Phrakhru Pitak Nanthakhun have wrapped monastic robes around trees to protect forests from logging, a practice documented by anthropologist Susan Darlington. No one cuts down a monk lightly, and the monks involved have risked arrest and even assassination. In Cambodia, Khmer Rouge rule devastated the religion: monks were forced to disrobe, temples were destroyed, and one researcher estimates that 80 percent or more of temple texts were lost. Ordinations restarted after 1979, and numbers grew to more than 50,000 monks by the late 1990s, while Dhammayietra peace walks led by monks began in 1992.

Buddhist care has entered public institutions too: a 2021 survey by researchers at Harvard Divinity School, Brandeis, and other schools reached more than 400 Buddhist chaplains working in hospitals, universities, prisons, and the military in the United States. Buddhism is also diplomacy. India held its second Global Buddhist Summit in New Delhi in January 2026, drawing delegates from about 40 countries, and has sent Buddha relics on tours to Mongolia, Vietnam, and Thailand, while China funds monastic exchanges and summits of its own, a rivalry one analyst summed up as deep pockets against deep roots. An international Tipitaka chanting programme has run at least eighteen editions in Bodh Gaya, the eighteenth expecting about 5,000 monks and nuns to recite the canon where it began. Africa is a newer frontier. The Amitofo Care Centres, led by the monk Hui Li, run seven branches in six African countries, including Eswatini, Madagascar, and Namibia, raising orphaned children on a mix of schooling, Mandarin, Buddhist study, and kung fu. Uganda's first Buddhist monk, Bhante Buddharakkhita, was raised Catholic in Kampala, went to India in 1990 to study business, and came home seven years later in robes; his Uganda Buddhist Centre runs a meditation hall, a school, and a clinic, and his mother became the country's first Buddhist nun.

Western Buddhism has grown through immigrants, their children, and converts. Pew counted about 4.4 million Buddhists in the United States in 2020, about 1.3 percent of the population, up 22 percent from 2010, and an estimated 64 percent of adults were Asian by race and 21 percent White. Today its influence reaches far beyond its numbers, through mindfulness programs in hospitals, schools, and companies. At the same time, Pew data show a global decline: from 343 million in 2010 to 324 million in 2020, a drop largely driven by aging and low birth rates in East Asia, where Buddhist numbers fell by 22 percent, and by people raised Buddhist leaving, especially in Japan and South Korea. Pew's 2026 analysis found that for every 100 adults raised Buddhist, 12 had joined and 22 had left. In Japan about half of those raised Buddhist have left, and in South Korea about six in ten. Thailand, with the largest Buddhist population, has seen almost no such loss.

Buddhism and Its Neighbors in This Library

Readers moving through this collection will meet Buddhism again and again, and a short map may help. Jainism shares its sramana origins, its karma and rebirth, and its focus on

non-harm, while differing sharply on the soul, which Jains affirm and Buddhists deny. Hinduism shares much vocabulary, and its Upanishadic self is the very idea the Buddha argued against, though Vedanta and Mahayana came to influence one another. Daoism shaped Chan, and Chinese folk religion absorbed Buddhist hells, Guanyin, and ghost festivals. Shinto lived alongside Buddhism in a single system for over a thousand years, until Meiji policy forced them apart. Korean Muism, Burmese nat worship, and Thai spirit houses all sit beside Buddhism in daily life, and most ordinary people see no conflict in that. Cao Dai incorporated it as one of three great teachings, and Tenrikyo's founder was a Pure Land devotee before her revelation.

This means the history of Buddhism is, in large part, the history of its accommodation to local gods and ancestors. Purists have often objected, and yet that same flexibility is why it survived after vanishing from India. The Haligric reader looking for what is unique should look less to shared ideas such as karma and more to what only this tradition supplies: the analysis of not-self, the Four Noble Truths, the graded meditation manuals, and the discipline of the alms bowl.

Controversies and Fairness

Buddhism's reputation for peace in the Western imagination is often used to shield it from the scrutiny given to other religions. Journalist Sonia Faleiro's The Robe and the Sword, reviewed in April 2026, traces how Theravada Buddhism has become tied to nationalism, citizenship, and power in Sri Lanka, Myanmar, and Thailand, and places the blame on extremist monks and politicians who misuse that power, not on Buddhist practice itself. The record is more mixed, and this series holds it to the same standard as the others.

The early texts set a high bar against violence. On March 31, 2026, the Dalai Lama, then 90, endorsed Pope Leo XIV's Palm Sunday call to lay down arms amid wars in the Middle East and Ukraine, writing that violence only begets more violence. The Dhammapada says all tremble at punishment, so taking yourself as the example you should neither strike nor kill, and the Pali stories show the Buddha meeting aggression without force, from the killer Angulimala to the kings Ajatasattu and Pasenadi, whose victories and defeats only fed fresh enmity. Later Buddhist kingdoms still went to war, and some monks justified it, which is the gap the following cases show. The gravest case is Myanmar. Monks including Ashin Wirathu and the 969 Movement, along with the nationalist group known as Ma Ba Tha, spread anti-Muslim rhetoric in the years before the Myanmar military's 2017 campaign against the Rohingya, which drove hundreds of thousands of people into Bangladesh. The International Court of Justice heard the merits of The Gambia's genocide case against Myanmar in January 2026, and on November 3, 2026, it announced that it will deliver its ruling on November 19, 2026, about two weeks after this document was written. More than one million Rohingya remain in Bangladesh. Myanmar has said its army was responding to attacks on security personnel. The case is against the state, not against a religion, and many Burmese monks have opposed the violence, and some have died opposing the military. But religious nationalism played a real part, and Sri Lanka's Bodu Bala Sena has raised similar concerns about the Buddhist nationalism there. Its leader, the monk Galagodaaththe Gnanasara, was sentenced by a Colombo magistrate to nine months in prison for anti-Islam remarks made at a 2016 press briefing, and on June 23, 2026, the Colombo High Court upheld that sentence. Monks have sat in parliament too: in 2004 the Jathika Hela Urumaya, running only monks as candidates, won nine of 225 seats and went on to push a bill against unethical conversions and back the war against the Tamil Tigers, a move other Buddhists criticized. On February 20, 2026, hundreds of monks rallied in Colombo demanding that the clergy be consulted on affairs of state, that Buddhist values shape schools and government, that Buddhist archaeological sites be protected, and that non-Buddhists be kept out of the top offices, and they sent their appeal to President Anura Kumara Dissanayake. After the 2021 coup, reports describe some prominent monks allying with the junta, while others joined the opposition, and the sangha remains divided. Reuters reported in 2022 that Sitagu Sayadaw, once a hero of the 1988 uprising, had embraced junta leader Min Aung Hlaing as a benevolent king, and that a monk called Wathawa ran a militia from his

monastery claiming more than 4,000 armed followers, a figure resistance groups dispute. Wirathu himself, freed from sedition charges after the coup and given a national award by Min Aung Hlaing in 2023, told reporters in January 2026, as the junta-run election that the UN called neither free nor fair came to a close, that he had high hopes for the new army-aligned government. He calls the genocide allegations ridiculous.

Japan's record includes wartime support. Brian Daizen Victoria's Zen at War of 1997 documented how leading Zen institutions and teachers supported Japanese militarism, and the book forced a real reckoning, with several Japanese Buddhist bodies since issuing statements of repentance. Scholars dispute parts of his account, but the core finding stands.

Sexual abuse has reached Western convert communities too. Sogyal Rinpoche retired from Rigpa International in August 2017 after massive abuse allegations, and in February 2018 Shambhala's Kalapa Council acknowledged sexual harm between members and between teachers and students, the same month Andrea Winn's Project Sunshine report appeared. The pattern did not end there. In 2020 an investigation commissioned by the Foundation for the Preservation of the Mahayana Tradition found the preponderance of evidence supported allegations that its teacher Dagri Rinpoche had sexually assaulted or harassed at least five women, and he was removed. In spring 2026 the organization suspended Yangsi Rinpoche pending an investigation of a separate complaint, and it is defending a 2025 federal lawsuit alleging abuse of a girl by two affiliated monks, which it denies. Sri Lanka faced the issue in 2026, when the custodian of a sacred Bodhi tree in Anuradhapura was arrested over allegations involving a child, which he denies. He is Pallegama Hemarathana, 71, of the Jaya Sri Maha Bodhi temple, and on May 30, 2026, Vesak day, the Malwatte Chapter suspended him until his case ends. In Thailand, police arrested two former senior monks of a Bangkok temple on March 20, 2026, after seven novices, later joined by four more, accused them of sexual abuse. Southasia magazine reports that child protection authorities received complaints against 285 monks between May 2023 and May 2026, and that 27 led to formal charges.

Monks also stand in the middle of war. After five days of fighting on the Cambodia-Thailand border in July 2025 killed dozens and displaced more than 260,000 people, hundreds of monks marched in Phnom Penh on August 8 to honor the dead and pray for the ceasefire to hold. Fighting flared again in December 2025, and religion became a border weapon: Thai forces destroyed a statue of the Hindu god Vishnu in a disputed area that month and then set up a Buddha image in its place, which Cambodia called a breach of the truce, and on April 22, 2026, Thai ministers held a merit-making ceremony with chanting monks at the contested Ta Kwai temple, drawing a formal Cambodian protest.

War has reached the monasteries. On August 21, 2026, a military jet bombed a monastery in Myaung Township in Sagaing Region, where more than 100 people were staying for a Lent retreat, killing as many as 14, according to local resistance groups; the army says it attacks only legitimate targets. Disaster struck the sangha too. On March 28, 2025, a powerful earthquake centered near Mandalay, home to some 50,000 monks, buried many in their monasteries; monks sitting promotion exams in the U Hla Thein hall were caught when it collapsed, and the number of monks killed is still unknown. Buddhists have also been targets. In Thailand's mostly Muslim, Malay-speaking Deep South, where a separatist insurgency has killed nearly 7,000 people since 2004, gunmen shot monks at a temple in Narathiwat province on January 18, 2019, killing at least two. On March 18, 2025, at least five temples in Manhattan's Chinatown were vandalized, and a man was charged with hate crimes. During World War II, Japanese American Buddhists sent to the incarceration camps outnumbered Christians there, and to look less foreign they spoke of reverends and churches and set chants as hymns; the Buddhist Mission of North America took the name Buddhist Churches of America when it reopened its headquarters at the Topaz camp in Utah. On February 20, 2026, the day after the Japanese American Day of Remembrance, the Buddhist Church of Sacramento was defaced with white nationalist graffiti, and its minister, Rev. Yuki Sugahara, urged people not to answer hate with hate. In Bangladesh, Buddhists are a vulnerable minority, many of them indigenous peoples of the Chittagong

Hill Tracts. On September 28, 2025, in Khagrachhari district, three young Marma men were killed when security forces fired on a roadblock protesting the alleged rape of a Marma schoolgirl by settlers, and in January 2026 Sri Lankan monks appealed to Buddhists worldwide to defend Bangladesh's Buddhist heritage after reports of attacks on temples and homes.

Clergy misconduct is a live problem elsewhere. In Japan, a Tendai nun known as Eicho went public in January 2024, accusing a monk of sexually abusing her for fourteen years and a senior priest of the highest rank of enabling it, and the Tendai sect opened an investigation that March. In July 2025, a blackmail scandal in Thailand involving Wilawan Emsawat and senior monks led to disrobings and to police announcing background checks on about 300,000 monks, following a separate case in which an abbot of Wat Raikhing was accused of embezzling vast sums. It continued in 2026. On September 10, police arrested Phra Wachirayan Wi, 66, of Wat Phutthaisawan in Ayutthaya, on embezzlement and money laundering charges, saying about 89 million baht in renovation donations and amulet payments never reached the temple, and linking him to a sexual relationship with the woman accused of hiding the money. In China, Shi Yongxin, the high-profile abbot of the Shaolin Temple, was defrocked in July 2025 and placed under criminal investigation over alleged misuse of temple funds and improper relationships, according to statements by the temple and the Buddhist Association of China. He was indicted for bribery and embezzlement in March 2026, and at the end of May the Xinxiang Intermediate People's Court sentenced him to 24 years in prison. The state-run China Buddhist Association has also called for a nationwide ban on the Zhengjue Fellowship, a Chan-based movement founded in Taiwan by Xiao Pingshi in 1997, branding it a heterodox xie jiao in 2025. In Vietnam, the independent Unified Buddhist Church stays outside the state-approved order; its patriarch Thich Quang Do, held under house arrest at Saigon's Thanh Minh Zen Monastery from 2003 after appealing for democracy, was expelled from it in 2018 and died under surveillance on February 22, 2020, at 91. In the West, Zen and Vajrayana communities have faced repeated accounts of sexual abuse of students by teachers, in which the authority structures of guru and student made speaking out difficult. These communities have since begun to adopt ethics codes.

New technology raises fresh questions. In March 2026 reporters revealed that Yang Mun, a gentle East Asian monk with about 2.5 million Instagram followers who sold healing courses, was entirely AI-generated by a digital creator in Israel; a Buddhist nun-scholar called it a lie that exploits people's need for peace, because people trust a Buddhist monk. On February 24, 2026, Kyoto University's Seiji Kumagai unveiled Buddharoid, a humanoid robot running an AI called BuddhaBotPlus that gives spiritual advice, and the university says such machines may one day assist or replace some rituals.

The commercialization of practice is the mildest and most widespread issue. China shows its scale: one consultancy valued the country's temple economy at 80 to 90 billion yuan in 2023, with temple cafes, gift shops, ash storage for people and pets, and even AI divination aimed at young visitors seeking what one scholar calls light-touch spirituality. Ronald Purser's McMindfulness of 2019 argues that corporate mindfulness strips meditation of its ethical purpose and places the burden of stress on individuals instead of on workplaces. Advocates respond that a secular practice that reduces suffering is valuable whatever its packaging. Scholar Robert Sharf makes a deeper point: modern Buddhism has isolated meditative experience from ritual, doctrine, and community, and when a teacher's authority rests on claimed inner experience, personal charisma replaces institutional checks.

The future of the Dalai Lama's office is a contest between a religious authority and a state. In July 2025, days before his ninetieth birthday, the 14th Dalai Lama affirmed that the institution will continue, reversing his 2011 suggestion that it might not, and named the Gaden Phodrang Trust as the only body authorized to identify his reincarnation. China's Foreign Ministry replied that the search must take place in China and needs central government approval. The Tibetan Vajrayana document in this library covers that tradition in full.

Lumbini, the birthplace, has its own quarrel. On October 16, 2026, Nepal's cabinet named the famous singing nun Ani Choying Drolma vice-chair of the Lumbini Development Trust, and local campaigners protested at once, wanting a local Buddhist scholar instead and raising a 2018 money-laundering inquiry that was shelved in 2019; she says those questions were resolved. Control of the holiest site is still in dispute. Under the Bodh Gaya Temple Act of 1949, the Mahabodhi Temple is run by a committee with four Hindus and four Buddhists under the district magistrate. On June 30, 2025, India's Supreme Court declined to hear a petition from former minister Upendra Kushwaha seeking Buddhist-only management and sent him to the high court. Buddhists have long demanded its repeal, and monks' hunger strikes in 2025 spread into national protests. In August 2026, the Bihar chief minister met with the All India Buddhist Forum and promised to examine the matter, and a month-long hunger strike ended, with the forum warning that it could resume if no action was taken.

Sexuality and gender identity are also a live question. Early monastic rules barred the people called pandaka, a term covering a range of gender and sexual difference, from ordination, and scholar Jue Liang notes that the Thai Sangha Council tried in 2009 to ban the ordination of kathoey, while some transgender monastics have begun to find acceptance. In Taiwan the nun Shih Chao-hwei has argued for same-sex marriage on Buddhist grounds, and on August 11, 2012, at a monastery in Taoyuan, she officiated the country's first Buddhist lesbian wedding, of Yu Ya-ting and Huang Mei-yu, who vowed before a Buddha image and exchanged Buddhist beads. Taiwan legalized same-sex marriage in 2019, while other Buddhist leaders still hold more traditional views. Women's ordination, discussed above, and the treatment of Buddhism under Chinese state control remain open issues as well, the latter treated at length in the Tibetan document. Since January 1, 2026, Chinese law allows 5 to 15 days of detention for illegal religious activities, and more than a dozen cities now reward citizens for reporting unapproved gatherings, with Chengdu offering up to 800 yuan for a verified tip. None of these invalidates the tradition's insights. The Buddha's own teaching would suggest that an institution, too, is impermanent, conditioned, and capable of craving.

The Haligricity Lens

Buddhism's analysis of how suffering is produced is one of the closest parallels to the Tetralty in this library. The Twelve Links describe a moment-by-moment chain in which feeling gives rise to craving, and craving to grasping and action. The Tetralty's sequence, in which a feeling generates a thought, a thought generates a word, and a word generates an action, describes the same terrain in other language, and the Noble Eightfold Path works on all four at once: intention, speech, action, mindfulness of feeling. Buddhism adds a precise instruction about where to intervene. Between the feeling and the craving there is a gap, and a trained attention can stand in it.

Haligricity diverges at a key point, and it should say so plainly. Buddhism teaches that no permanent self can be found. Haligric practice teaches Be More You, and holds that the divine is present in all things, including in the person. These positions do not simply agree. Yet they may be closer than they look. To be more you, in a Haligric sense, was never meant as polishing an ego. Mahayana's Buddha-nature, the teaching that awakening is already in you waiting to be uncovered, is the Buddhist doctrine that stands nearest to it, and this library's Tibetan document already describes that resonance through Dzogchen.

The practices stand on their own and belong to anyone. Counting ten breaths, sending goodwill to one difficult person, saying the five recollections before the day starts, and caring for the sick as though caring for the Buddha do not require a person to accept any doctrine at all. The Buddha himself would have asked only whether they work.

Closing

When the Buddha lay dying between two sal trees, Ananda wept, and the old teacher called him over. Have I not told you, he said, that all things dear to us must change? Then he told the monks one last thing: to strive on, with care.

The tree at Bodh Gaya still stands in its descendant, and pilgrims still sit under it. Rice still goes into a bowl at dawn in Laos. A name is still being chanted softly in a hospital room in Kyoto. The breath you took a moment ago is already gone, and here is another. Begin there. You are the current.